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Theoretical Sampling, Saturation, and Sorting

Turns and twists in your research journey leave you with questions about directions to take, how quickly to proceed, and what you will have when you arrive. Theoretical sampling prompts you to retrace your steps or take a new path when you have some tentative categories and emerging, but incomplete ideas. By going back into the empirical world and collecting more data about the properties of your category, you can saturate its properties with data and write more memos, making them more analytic as you proceed. Afterwards, you are ready to sort and integrate memos on your theoretical categories. You may find it helpful to chart the course with diagrams and maps that explain what you have and where you are going.

Suppose that you have arrived at some preliminary—and perhaps tentative—categories. While making earlier comparisons between data, you selected some focused codes and wrote memos on them. Now several categories look like promising abstract tools for rendering your data analytically. Yet one quick reading of these memos tells you: These categories are intriguing but thin. You have not yet defined your categories and their properties clearly. Too much still remains assumed, unknown, or questionable. Instead you want robust categories that stand on firm, not shaky grounds. What do you do? How can grounded theory strategies advance your analytic thinking at this stage of the research?

The answer is to gather more data that focus on the *category* and its properties. This strategy is *theoretical sampling*, which means seeking and collecting pertinent data to elaborate and refine categories in your emerging theory.

Theoretical sampling means seeking pertinent data to *develop* your emerging *theory*. The main purpose of theoretical sampling is to elaborate and refine the categories constituting your theory. You conduct theoretical sampling by sampling to develop the properties of your category(ies) until no new properties emerge.

You conduct theoretical sampling by sampling to develop the properties of your category(ies) until no new properties emerge. Thus, you *saturate* your categories with data and subsequently *sort* and/or diagram them to integrate your

emerging theory.¹ Conducting theoretical sampling can keep you from becoming stuck in unfocused analyses. Glaser and Strauss (1967; Glaser, 1978, 1998, 2001; Strauss, 1987) created the strategies of theoretical sampling, saturation, and sorting. Despite Glaser's continued efforts to explicate what theoretical sampling and saturation entail and Strauss and Corbin's (1990, 1998) explanations, researchers commonly misunderstand how grounded theorists use these strategies.

This chapter consists of guidelines for conducting theoretical sampling, saturating your categories and sorting them into an integrated theoretical statement. I draw upon an interview with Jane Hood² and her book *Becoming a Two-Job Family* (1983), as well as on other published materials to illustrate theoretical sampling. Hood is one of the very few authors whose grounded theory analysis and methodological decisions are both explicit. Because qualitative researchers routinely adopt the term 'saturation,' I qualify its meaning in grounded theory, show how it differs from standard understandings and suggest where some grounded theorists themselves have taken it amiss. The chapter ends with ideas about how to do theoretical sorting.

In the interview excerpt below, Jane Hood recounts how she used grounded theory strategies in her study. In her book, she specifies that these were not dual-career families. Rather they were working and lower-middle-class parents both of whom had full-time jobs or were one-career-one-job families. The thrust of Hood's research shifted as she studied her initial data. Originally, she had planned to study married women's self-concepts and friendship networks when they returned to work after having children. Early in Hood's fieldwork, however, she discovered an intriguing family issue: how couples negotiated childcare and housework when women returned to the workforce. As a result, she shifted her data collection to address this issue. Hood's data include 1) material from a small pilot study, 2) in-depth first interviews of 16 wives, 3) in-depth second interviews of these wives, 4) interviews with their husbands, 5) a follow-up questionnaire six years later, 6) telephone interviews she conducted six to seven years after the second round of interviews, and 7) fieldnotes about each interview and its setting, phone call, and informal meeting.

When I talked with her, Hood described how she adopted grounded theory strategies from the beginning of her research:

It looks like I have something going on here [in her data]. Let's say, in my case it was with women who were working because they really wanted to. Women who were working because they wanted to weren't getting much help from their husbands with housework in my two-job family study. I began to wonder whether women who were working because they *had* to and whose income was really valued by their husbands might get more help but the way I had done my [initial] sampling I had asked for volunteers to be interviewed about the experience of going back to work after having been home full-time. So the volunteers tended to be people who wanted to tell me how wonderful it was to work. I wasn't getting people who were going to work more reluctantly because they had to. But since I was really interested in how women who returned to work kind of bargained with their spouses about getting help with childcare and housework, it was critical that I look at people with a little more bargaining power, who went to work

because their husbands really *needed* them to work. So then I went out and *looked* for those women and lo and behold it made a big difference.

I did have already one or two women in my original collection of seven or eight interviews who were working because they had to and that gave me a clue that that was an important distinction. Then I *expanded* on that category and that was theoretical sampling. Because I had a category of women who went back to work because they wanted to—for self-fulfillment—and another category who went back to work because their family really needed the money.

[The categories] came out of analyzing the data ... I would ask them, 'Why did you go back to work?' Some of the women would say 'Well I went back to work because I was bored at home,' 'I went back to work because I was getting eczema and I went to the doctor and the doctor told me that I had to get out of the house,' or 'I went back to work because I really needed more than just staying at home'... —for self-fulfillment reasons.

I coded reasons for going back to work. I was also coding the kind of help they were getting from their husbands and the kinds of things their husbands were saying about their income. When they went back to work because they wanted to, their husbands were more likely to be saying, 'Well we don't really need you to work. If you can't handle the housework, then you can just quit,' etc. They didn't have much bargaining power because their husbands weren't recognizing their income as necessary. They had gone back to work for self-fulfillment.

Then I realized that when husbands would say—because I would ask husbands, 'What would happen if she quit?' and they would say 'Well, I'd have to take a second job' or 'I don't know *what* we'd do if she quit.' In those cases, husbands *couldn't* say, 'Well, you know, she just can quit whenever she wants.'

'Quit whenever she wants' became a really important analytical code as far as reasons for going back to work: self-fulfillment vs. economic necessity—a few people did both. But what was really important is that the husband recognized and was willing to say that they couldn't easily get along without her income. And that they would have to make major changes—maybe sell their house, cut back on lots of things or—major changes in their lifestyle would be required if the wife quit work. If she could quit whenever she wanted, if that's what the husband basically said, then they described her income as 'icing on the cake.' That was another category that developed from the work. It's funny how many guys referred to it that way, 'icing on the cake.' 'It's a little extra.' When they thought of it that way, they didn't see her as a coprovider—that was part of the definition of a secondary provider, they described her income as 'icing on the cake' ... Even when a woman's salary was paying the whole mortgage payment, this guy said, well he was really putting the bread on the table; he wouldn't recognize her as a coprovider. She made the same amount of income as many women who were recognized as making a necessary contribution. He wouldn't let go of the provider role.

This is what's different [about grounded theory], I suppose, when we're developing these categories and developing an analysis as we go along, we are really looking at the data as we code and developing a grounded concept. We call them categories but it's really grounded in the data.

Hood's coding and sampling methods shaped her substantive study from its beginnings.³ Because she had initially expected to study changes in women's self-concepts and friendship networks, she only interviewed wives during her first round of interviews. Yet her early analysis revealed that she needed to interview husbands as well as focus more on women who had financial pressures to return to work. Her *in vivo* codes such as 'quit whenever she wants' and 'icing on the cake' provide vivid indicators of certain husbands' stances toward having their wives' work. Such codes also gave Hood strong clues about how these husbands' views played out in interaction.

Note how Hood traced the conditions under which women gained bargaining power. Through following what she defined in her data, she linked bargaining power to marital roles. In Hood's book, role analysis in marriage emerges as a dominant theme. Her work fits into the family of theoretical codes on roles and extends knowledge of how couples enact roles. Granted, other researchers might construct the study differently, according to what they saw in the data. Another researcher, for example, might also identify the bargaining issues but pursue a different line of analysis with them, such as the partners' emotions about bargaining. Still another researcher might interview lesbian or gay couples who take neither the concept of gender nor conventional gender roles for granted. Rich data can spark multiple directions of inquiry.

Hood built on her interest in marital roles and developed a theoretical framework and proposed testable hypotheses that locate bargaining power within the context of the marriage. She showed how these wives' bargaining power varied in relation to each spouse's commitment to and investment in the marital relationship, work and family priorities, the extent of the wife's role overload, and the couple's style of resolving conflicts. Hood's work reveals how a researcher acts on her theoretical and substantive interests and engages her data as she constructs a grounded theory through making comparisons at each analytic level. Consider several of Hood's concluding remarks in her book:

None of the couples in this book decided to become coproviders in order to adopt a more equal division of labour. Instead they became two-job couples either because the wife needed to get out of the house or the family needed money, or both. In the process of becoming a two-job family, some couples also developed a more equal balance of power in their marriages and a more equal division of labour in the household. This move towards equality was, however, an unforeseen and unintended consequence of becoming coproviders.

... Couples who purposefully decide to share roles are like couples who began to share roles 'without really thinking about it' in at least one important respect, however. Most find that the new common ground created by role sharing and the increased communication necessary to maintain role-sharing relationships brings them closer together. (1983: 197-198)

Theoretical Sampling

Distinguishing Theoretical Sampling from Other Types of Sampling

To understand and to use theoretical sampling, we must relinquish our preconceptions about what sampling means. Sampling to develop a researcher's

emerging theoretical categories distinguishes theoretical sampling from other forms of sampling. Sometimes qualitative researchers claim to use theoretical sampling but do not follow the logic of grounded theory. They mistake theoretical sampling for the following types of sampling:

- Sampling to address initial research questions
- Sampling to reflect population distributions
- Sampling to find negative cases
- Sampling until no new data emerge.

These sampling strategies mistake theoretical sampling for conventional qualitative research approaches. Of course anyone who writes a research proposal seeks data to address his or her research questions—but this sampling is of an initial type. Initial sampling provides a point of departure, not of theoretical elaboration and refinement. We cannot assume to know our categories in advance, much less have them contained in our beginning research questions. Grounded theory logic presupposes that we will construct categories through the comparative methods of analyzing data.

Remember that criteria for initial sampling differ from those you invoke while theoretical sampling. Initial sampling in grounded theory is where you start whereas theoretical sampling directs you where to go. For initial sampling, you establish sampling criteria for people, cases, situations, and/or settings before you enter the field. You need to find relevant materials for your study whether that leads you to sampling people, settings, or larger structures such as government agencies or organizations.

Initial sampling in grounded theory is where you start, whereas theoretical sampling directs you where to go.

If, for example, you plan to study customer service relationships, gaining access to observe actual encounters is a prerequisite. What you will see and hear depends, of course, on your position in the organization and how you negotiate it. You will have access to some things but not others.⁴ If you obtain permission to interview customer service agents but not to observe them, then your study shifts in another direction.

Seemingly straightforward topics may soon become complex. If you wish to explore drinking among people with disabilities, then you must start with at least a provisional definition stating what the term ‘disability’ will cover. Then you need to find out what drinking—and disability—mean to your participants and find out if you need to talk with their families or friends. You must decide whether you will include people with disabilities who view themselves as recovering alcoholics. Topics that prompt you to contact certain people but not others already circumscribe what you address. You should explicate and, not least among your tasks, examine your own preconceptions about drinking.

Theoretical sampling also follows a different logic than sampling techniques for traditional quantitative research design. The purpose of theoretical sampling is to obtain data to help you explicate your categories. When your categories are full, they reflect qualities of your respondents’ experiences and provide a useful analytic handle for understanding them. In short, theoretical

sampling pertains only to conceptual and theoretical development; it is *not* about representing a population or increasing the statistical generalizability of your results. Many quantitative studies require random samples of people whose characteristics are representative of the population under study. Whereas quantitative researchers want to use their data to make statistical inferences about their target populations, grounded theorists aim to fit their emerging theories with their data. Quantitative researchers test preconceived hypotheses; grounded theorists sometimes offer the grist for emergent hypotheses that other researchers might pursue.

Colleagues and teachers who invoke the logic of quantitative research often mistakenly advise qualitative researchers to make their samples represent distributions of larger populations. The error of this advice lies in assuming that qualitative research aims for generalizability. Although this strategy may be useful for initial sampling, it does not fit the logic of grounded theory and can result in the researcher collecting unnecessary and conceptually thin data.⁵ During our talk, Jane Hood commented on understanding theoretical sampling:

Very few people do [understand it]. I really think it's a craft ... You need somebody to give you feedback as you're trying to learn how to do this because there is a subtle difference between theoretical sampling and other kinds of purposeful sampling. Theoretical sampling is purposeful sampling but it's purposeful sampling according to categories that one develops from one's analysis and these categories are not based upon quotas; they're based on theoretical concerns. And—the authors of textbooks don't get it. The authors of textbooks typically say [something like], 'Oh, you don't have enough women; go get more.' No, that's not theoretical sampling. That's basically quota sampling or sampling on demographic characteristics. There's nothing wrong with starting out that way *but* that's your first step. Theoretical sampling really makes grounded theory special and is the major strength of grounded theory *because* theoretical sampling allows you to tighten what I call the corkscrew or the hermeneutic spiral so that you end up with a theory that perfectly matches your data. Because you choose the next people to talk to or the next cases to find based upon the [theoretical] analysis and you don't waste your time with all sorts of things that have nothing to do with your developing theory.⁶

As Hood states, many researchers sample different settings or individuals to reflect empirical distributions or situations but they are not conducting theoretical sampling. For example, a specialist in organizations may plan to sample different businesses with both strict and loose systems of authority. This plan may produce interesting contrasts in data but it does not constitute theoretical sampling. Again, until researchers construct conceptual categories from the data and sample to develop these categories, they are not conducting theoretical sampling.

The search for negative cases raises more ambiguous questions. Whether or not sampling negative cases complements or contradicts grounded theory depends on the situation. Qualitative researchers often use negative cases to find new variables or to provide alternative explanations from their developing theory. The logic of negative cases assumes asking whether the data include individuals,

situations, or themes that do not fit your analysis. Virginia Olesen asks a further question: Did you try to find those cases? (Personal communication, June 5, 2005).

The source of the negative cases and how the researcher uses these cases shapes their relative fit with grounded theory. Did these cases arise in the data or did the researcher *import* them into the research process as though they furthered theoretical sampling? If the researcher does not define negative cases in the comparative analysis of his or her data, a search for them may result in importing them. If negative cases emerge in the data, however, these cases may indicate the need to refine one's emerging theory. Examining negative cases comes close to the emphasis on variation in a category or process and analytic density in grounded theory (Strauss & Corbin, 1990). Becker (1998) points out that some researchers consider hypothetical negative cases or draw on fiction for possibilities. To the extent that such practices cause the researcher to stray from their studied empirical world, they remain inconsistent with the grounded theory emphasis on building one's analysis from it.⁷

Perhaps the most common error occurs when researchers confuse theoretical sampling with gathering data until they find the same patterns reoccurring. This strategy differs from theoretical sampling because these researchers have not aimed their data-gathering toward explicit development of *theoretical* categories derived from analyses of their studied worlds. Instead, the patterns describe empirical *themes* in their studied worlds.

Some forms of sampling come much closer to theoretical sampling than others. Pertti Alasuutari's (1996) sampling strategies share similarities with theoretical sampling. He notes that his strategic selection of case study examples resembled theoretical sampling; however, his objective differed. Alasuutari's ethnographic study of a local Finnish tavern focused on the lives of regular male patrons who were heavy drinkers. Through his studies of alcohol use (1992, 1995), he aimed to gain a 'unified picture of different cultural logics within which the same historical structural conditions are viewed in people's lived experience,' not to develop a general theory (1996, p. 376). Nevertheless, his focus on cultural logics led to a sophisticated cultural theory of alcoholism (1992). When discussing the research process involved in this project, Alasuutari states:

In ethnographic research the testing of hypotheses may have to do with more than just the kinds of thing you're making observations about or the kinds of subjects that you raise with the informants. On the basis of your results you may decide to move on and collect a new data set, as I did in the AA group project. When I learned that A-Guilds in Finland had their own journal, it seemed a good idea to go through all its back volumes to determine whether the 'treatment philosophy' I had discovered in Tampere was a local or a more national phenomenon. (1995: 172)

The Logic of Theoretical Sampling

Theoretical sampling involves starting with data, constructing tentative ideas about the data, and then examining these ideas through further empirical inquiry.

Consider how Hood (1983) kept moving back and forth between data collection and data analysis throughout her research. Codes became categories. Early categories were suggestive but not yet definitive. Further data collection strengthened them but Hood then saw new gaps in her nascent analysis. She returned to the field and asked further questions—and kept writing and analyzing.

Memo-writing leads directly to *theoretical sampling*. Theoretical sampling is strategic, specific, and systematic. Because you intend to use it to elaborate and refine your theoretical categories, conducting theoretical sampling depends on having already identified a category(ies). This pivotal grounded theory strategy helps you to delineate and develop the properties of your category and its range of variation.

Writing memos has already enabled you to flag incomplete categories and gaps in your analysis. Engaging in theoretical sampling prompts you to *predict* where and how you can find needed data to fill gaps and to saturate categories. Like Hood's hunches, your predictions arise from your immediate analytic work. They are not off-hand conjectures. Rather, they emerge from your grounded comparative analysis of earlier data. Follow hunches about where to find data that will illuminate these categories and then go *collect* these data. Next, code them and compare your codes with each other, earlier codes, and your emerging categories. Write increasingly more abstract and conceptual memos as you proceed to record your new comparisons—and all those flashes of insight you have while filling out your categories. Theoretical sampling ensures that you construct full and robust categories and leads you to clarify relationships between categories.

Theoretical sampling not only helps you fill out the properties of your major categories, you can learn more about how a basic process develops and changes. When you engage in theoretical sampling, you seek statements, events, or cases that will illuminate your categories. Like Hood, you may add new participants or observe in new settings. Quite possibly, you may ask earlier participants further questions or inquire about experiences that you had not covered before.

How does theoretical sampling benefit your analysis from the start? From early in the research process, you check emerging questions as you compare data with data. Note how Hood's comparisons between data led her to make conjectures about her categories that she subsequently checked out through further data collection. Her story about how she used theoretical sampling reveals how she formed analytic questions and used deductive logic. For example, Hood predicted that married women's bargaining power increased with their husbands' awareness and open acknowledgment of the wives' vital financial contribution to the household. Then Hood checked her hunches and found them confirmed in subsequent data collection. In this sense, theoretical sampling entails both of what we commonly refer to as inductive and deductive reasoning.

The particular form of reasoning invoked in grounded theory makes it an abductive method, because grounded theory includes *reasoning* about experience for making theoretical conjectures and then checking them through further experience.³ Abductive reasoning about the data starts with the data and subsequently moves toward hypothesis formation (Deely, 1990; Fann, 1970; Rosenthal, 2004). In brief, abductive inference entails considering all possible

theoretical explanations for the data, forming hypotheses for each possible explanation, checking them empirically by examining data, and pursuing the most plausible explanation.

At this point, researchers take their ideas emanating from experience, form a follow-up hypothesis, and then move back to check this hypothesis in experience (Peirce, 1958).

Thus after you examine cases, you make a logical inference that offers a theoretical interpretation of the relationships between these cases, and then you return to the field to check and evaluate your inference. These processes are central to theoretical sampling and are apparent in Hood's reflections during the interview about how she did theoretical sampling.

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You ... go back and forth between data collection and analysis and as your theory develops through the constant comparative method, you know with each step which data you need to collect in order to refine your theory. So in a way I see grounded theory as a combination of inductive and, to some extent, deductive work. You're inductively developing theory and then you're at least trying out your hunches here continuously ... We can call it an abductive method. ... I wouldn't say we are exactly testing theory, depending what you mean by testing, but we are testing our hunches.

As Hood's remarks imply, conducting theoretical sampling advances your analysis. Simultaneously it keeps you from getting stuck in either unfocused data collection or foiled analyses. Use theoretical sampling to keep you moving toward such emergent objectives such as:

- To delineate the properties of a category
- To check hunches about categories
- To saturate the properties of a category
- To distinguish between categories
- To clarify relationships between emerging categories
- To identify variation in a process.

Theoretical sampling is *emergent*. It follows constructing tentative categories. You cannot know which ideas you will need to sample before you begin analysis. The specific reason why you conduct theoretical sampling depends on the analytic problems you are grappling with and what ideas, gaps, ambiguities, and questions subsequently arise.⁹

Identifying problems and seeking solutions for them takes a certain amount of candor and distance. Are your categories analytically thin? Insufficiently supported? Are your ideas about the relationships between categories hazy? Are they indistinct but perhaps suggestive? Good researchers learn to recognize such analytic problems—and work to resolve them. Theoretical sampling in grounded theory provides a valuable tool for developing your analysis and

correcting trouble spots. Grappling with analytic problems is part of the research process. Feeling confused and uncertain—but learning to tolerate the ambiguity—shows your growth as a researcher. Researchers who treat the analytic process as transparent often have superficial analyses.

Conducting theoretical sampling encourages you to follow up on analytic leads. As a result, you improve your study through:

- Specifying the relevant properties of your categories
- Increasing the precision of your categories
- Providing the substance to move your material from description to analysis
- Making your analysis more abstract and generalizable
- Grounding your conjectures in data
- Explicating the analytic links between or among categories
- Increasing the parsimony of your theoretical statements.

Theoretical sampling gives you the data to delineate the properties of a category. When I was trying to sort through how people experienced a serious chronic illness, their accounts abounded with tales of uneven days, troublesome symptoms, and lost time. When comparing these accounts, I devised the category, 'experiencing intrusive illness.'¹⁰ Certainly the category itself is mundane and specific to illness as stated, but what does it include? How might I conceptualize it? For what types of experiences beyond illness might experiencing unwanted intrusions have relevance?

After gathering more data through theoretical sampling, I defined the category of intrusive illness by its analytic properties as demanding continued attention, allotted time, and forced accommodation. Note how these properties fit the following account:

There's a lot of things I can't do. ... When I go to night school ... I have to go straight home to lay down before I do, or I can't go, where years ago I wouldn't have had to do that.

And I have really had problems with lights. I can't be in a room that has fluorescent lighting without wearing special glasses. So if I go to class at night, I have to sit there with sunglasses on. Then that makes me even more tired. It makes my eyes swell shut ... And I've also missed three classes and before I've never missed class. (Charmaz, 1991a: 43)

As I examined many cases and incidents, I aimed to make the properties of the category of intrusive illness reflect the actions people took toward their illness and reveal meanings they attributed to it. In their view, the intrusiveness of their illness imposed special demands on them if they were to maintain some semblance of their earlier lives. The properties of this category seem straightforward although they provide grist for making abstract statements about time and self. When conducting theoretical sampling about experiencing an intrusive illness, I gathered more data on how people defined their uneven days, what allotting time to illness-related tasks to get through the day meant to them, when they felt forced to accommodate to illness, which accommodations they made, and how

they saw themselves. For example, one woman wanted to minimize her co-workers' knowledge of her condition. She felt forced to complete her work assignments early in the day before fatigue overtook her and tried to camouflage her symptoms in the afternoon. As her problems with getting through the workday increased, she realized that she could no longer hope to hold on until retirement eight years hence. When asking about such accommodations, few questions elicited many stories. Moreover, I witnessed events that illuminated how intrusive illness affected my research participants and was able to piece their implicit views and actions together as I developed the analysis.

Note that theoretical sampling gives you the material to compare theoretical category with category. Think about whether you have lumped properties under one category that might call for constructing separate, distinctive categories. Experiencing intrusive illness differs from the other two ways of experiencing illness, as an interruption or immersion in it. By defining each category by its properties, I raise the analytic level of the category and sharpen the definitions of each.

Delineating links between views and actions is one way of sharpening your ideas. Subsequently, an analysis of mundane experiences in a field setting became more analytic, abstract and potentially generalizable. Theoretical sampling gives your work analytic depth and precision. As you engage in theoretical sampling, your work gains clarity and generality that transcends the immediate topic. By focusing on your *theoretical categories* rather than on a single empirical topic, theoretical sampling leads you to sample across substantive areas. Thus, engaging in theoretical sampling can encourage you to raise your theory to a formal, more abstract level that cuts across different substantive areas.

If we moved the analysis of having an intrusive experience across substantive fields, where would we take it? Certainly some types of caregiving demand continued attention, allotted time and forced accommodation—and may be unwelcome, similar to having a serious illness. A few weeks ago, a caregiver whose father was dying of cancer read portions of my book. She commented on how my analysis of time applied to her caregiving experience as well as to her father's situation. People who find themselves mired in unexpected, unpleasant legal or bureaucratic battles might offer insights on how an intrusive experience encroaches on their lives. Experiencing identity theft or obtaining special services at school for a child with learning disabilities are two examples. In each situation, we could explore how properties of experiencing an unwanted and persistent situation shape qualities of time—and subsequent selves and situations. We might compare what began as an unwelcome, sometimes shocking disruption with situations that began as inconvenient and became intrusive. We could look at how and when the intrusive experience takes over people's lives. Depending on how encompassing it is, life changes may occur that have consequences for these individuals' development of self. Had I taken my analysis of self and time beyond the experience of illness, I could have constructed a formal theory of them.

Anchoring your categories in a solid substantive base first gives you leads about where and how to proceed in other areas. Jane Hood's book provides a

substantive grounded theory of marital bargaining about family work.¹¹ Through her analysis, she builds a foundation from which further research across fields could generate a formal theory of both silent and strategic bargaining. She might establish, for example, a theoretical continuum between gradual accommodation and explicit negotiations. In any case, she has the initial material to seek new individuals and groups involved in bargaining. Then she could check how participants' relative equal or unequal power and different stakes in the outcome of bargaining affect how it proceeds and what happens as a result of it.

Using Theoretical Sampling

You can use theoretical sampling in both early and later stages of your research—if you have categories to direct your sampling. Use theoretical sampling as a strategy to narrow your focus on emerging categories and as a technique to develop and refine them. Begin theoretical sampling when you have some preliminary categories to develop. Theoretical sampling helps you to check, qualify, and elaborate the boundaries of your categories and to specify the relations among categories. Initially, theoretical sampling helps you to fill out the properties of a category so that you can create an analytic definition and explication of it. Later, theoretical sampling may help you demonstrate links among categories.

Some attempts to conduct theoretical sampling may not be particularly theoretical. In this case, researchers pursue an interesting finding but they may not theorize its significance. They fail to push the boundaries of a substantive finding and answer the "So what?" question. Of what larger, more abstract theoretical category or problem is this finding a part? Theoretical sampling means more than following up on intriguing earlier codes, which good researchers routinely do. Conduct theoretical sampling after you have already defined and tentatively conceptualized relevant ideas that indicate areas to probe with more data. Otherwise, early theoretical sampling may result in one or more of the common grounded theory pitfalls:

- Premature closure of analytic categories
- Trite or redundant categories
- Over-reliance on overt statements for elaborating and checking categories
- Unfocused or unspecified categories.

Textbook authors often treat theoretical sampling as a procedure that researchers conduct through interviews. Theoretical sampling is less of an explicit procedure than a *strategy* that you invoke and fit to your specific study. Methods for conducting theoretical sampling vary accordingly. Theoretical sampling can entail studying documents, conducting observations, or participating in new social worlds as well as interviewing or reinterviewing with a focus on your theoretical categories.

What you look for through theoretical sampling and *how* you conduct it depends on your purposes in doing it. Consistent with the logic of grounded

theory, theoretical sampling is emergent. Your developing ideas shape what you do, areas you tap and questions you pose while theoretical sampling.

When I was trying to figure out how people with chronic illnesses defined the passage of time, I went back to several participants whom I had interviewed before to ask them more focused questions about how they perceived times of earlier crisis and when time seemed to slow, quicken, drift, or drag. Because such topics resonated with their experiences, they responded to esoteric questions and offered numerous insights about meanings of temporal duration. For example, when I studied their stories, I realized that chronically ill adults implicitly located their self-concepts in the past, present, or future.¹² These timeframes reflected the form and content of self and mirrored hopes and dreams for self as well as beliefs and understandings about self. Hence, I made 'the self in time' a major category. Thereafter, I asked more people how they saw themselves in relation to the past, present, or future. An elderly working-class woman said without hesitation:

What you look for through theoretical sampling and how you conduct it depends on your purposes in doing it. Consistent with the logic of grounded theory, theoretical sampling is emergent. Your developing ideas shape what you do and the questions you pose while theoretical sampling.

I see myself in the future now. If you'd asked where I saw myself eight months ago, I would have said, 'the past.' I was so angry then because I had been so active. And to go downhill as fast as I did—I felt life had been awfully cruel to me. Now I see myself in the future because there's something the Lord wants me to do. Here I sit all crumpled in this chair not being able to do anything for myself and still there's a purpose for me to be here. [*Laughs.*] I wonder what it could be. (Charmaz, 1991a: 256)

Through theoretical sampling you can elaborate the meaning of your categories, discover variation within them, and define *gaps among categories*. By gaps between categories, I mean that your current categories do not account for the full range of relevant experience. Theoretical sampling relies on comparative methods for discovering these gaps and finding ways to fill them. These methods are particularly helpful when you attempt to analyze liminal experience and tacit views. For example, as I talked with people about their experiences of illness and time and wrote memos about the properties of locating one's self in time, I realized that meanings of the past differed (Charmaz, 1991a). For some people, the past was a tangled web in which they felt ensnared. They sought to explain and account for past events that had brought them to the present. Other people located themselves in a familiar past because the present seem so alien and inexplicable. Still others located themselves in a reconstructed past that shone bright with happiness, fullness, and vibrancy when juxtaposed against a lived present with which they did not identify. As I analyzed differences in how people located themselves in the past, my subcategories depicting their pasts, 'the past as a tangled web,' 'the familiar past and the inexplicable present,' and 'the reconstructed past,' refined the larger category of the self in the past and showed how living in the past varied.

Discovering Variation

Variation within a process usually becomes apparent while you are conducting theoretical sampling. For example, when living with physical impairment, people show considerable variation in how they act and feel about it. They may ignore impairment, minimize it, struggle against it, reconcile themselves to it, embrace it, or adapt to it.¹³ Not only may these ways of living with impairment differ among people, but also they may differ over time with the same individual. I wanted to see what changes occurred over time, so I talked with a subset of my interview participants for a number of years. Being selective about which data you seek and where you seek them aids you to see variation in the studied process. You focus on certain actions, experiences, events, or issues, *not on individuals per se*, to understand how, when, and why your theoretical categories vary. However, you will likely gain more knowledge about those experiences, events, or issues that you seek to treat theoretically through observing or talking with certain individuals. For example, one of my main categories was 'immersion in illness' (Charmaz, 1991a). Major properties of immersion include recasting life around illness, slipping into illness routines, pulling into one's inner circle, facing dependency, and experiencing an altered (slowed) time perspective. Activities of all sorts took longer but not everyone's time perspective changed, despite being immersed in illness.

How could I account for this phenomenon? What supported maintaining the time perspective of a former workaday world? By going back through my data, I gained some leads. Then I talked with more people about specific experiences and events that influenced their time perspective. Theoretical sampling helped me to refine the analysis and make it more complex. I then added a category 'variations in immersion' to highlight and account for different experiences of immersion in illness.

My earlier interviews contained hints that immersion in illness varied and affected experiencing time but the significance of this variation only occurred to me after I developed the larger category of immersion in illness. I had begun to see variations in what being immersed in illness was like when I compared telling events and specific experiences of people with different illnesses, with different life situations, and different ages. Subsequently, theoretical sampling helped me to define more specific forms of variation. For example, I sampled to learn how illness and time differed for people who spent months in darkened rooms and how both varied when people anticipated later improvement or defined their situations as facing continued uncertainty. Demarcations of time stretched when people had few activities, little companionship, and minimal responsibilities. Making comparisons explicit through successive memos enabled me to draw connections that I did not initially discern. The memo became a short section of a chapter that begins as follows and then goes on to detail each remaining point:

Variations in Immersion

A lengthy immersion in illness shapes daily life and affects how one experiences time. Conversely, ways of experiencing time dialectically affect the qualities of immersion in illness. The picture above of immersion and time has sharp outlines. What sources of variation soften or alter the picture

of immersion and time? The picture may vary according to the person's 1) type of illness, 2) kind of medication, 3) earlier time perspective, 4) life situation, and 5) goals.

The type of illness shapes the experience and way of relating to time. Clearly trying to manage diabetes necessitates gaining a heightened awareness of timing the daily routines. But the effects of the illness may remain much more subtle. People with Sjögren's syndrome, for example, may have periods of confusion when they feel wholly out of synchrony with the world around them. For them, things happen too quickly, precisely when their bodies and minds function too slowly. Subsequently, they may retreat into routines to protect themselves. Lupus patients usually must retreat because they cannot tolerate the sun. Sara Shaw covered her windows with black blankets when she was extremely ill. Thus, her sense of chronological time became further distorted as day and night merged together into an endless flow of illness. (Charmaz, 1991a: 93)

Theoretical sampling focuses further data collection to refine key categories in your research. You can then define these categories quite explicitly and identify their properties and parameters. Your subsequent memo-writing becomes more precise, analytic, and incisive. Theoretical sampling keeps you moving between targeted data collection and analytic memo-writing. You follow leads, check out hunches, and refine your ideas in successive memos. Because theoretical sampling forces you to check your ideas against direct empirical realities, you have solid materials and sound ideas with which to work. You gain confidence in your perceptions of your data and in your theorizing about them.

The logic of theoretical sampling implies a quick, focused method of gathering pinpointed data. Some grounded theorists present it as an unproblematic step in refining theory. Yet conducting theoretical sampling entails more than technical and analytic procedures. It brings you back into empirical worlds with all their ambiguities and tensions.

Empirical worlds have their own rules and traditions. Theoretical sampling may not fit them. Textbook explanations of theoretical sampling seldom take into account interactional reciprocities and situational demands. These technical explanations ignore relationships and reciprocities in the field and all the actual work it takes to gain ready access to information. You may not be able to dash in, grab the needed data, and dart back to your desk. The lines between involvement and distance in field research often blur and may require continual renegotiation. Remember that human beings are unlikely to relish being treated as objects from which you extract data. Reciprocities are important, and listening and being there are among them. Some researchers may command access on the basis of their authority and the prestige of their projects. Many other researchers cannot. Instead we gain access through the trust that emerges through establishing on-going relationships and reciprocities. Ignoring such reciprocities not only weakens your chances of obtaining telling data but, moreover, dehumanizes your research participants—and yourself.

The logistics of legitimacy, formal access, and entry also pose problems. During a recent presentation on grounded theory, one researcher asked me, 'How do you do theoretical sampling when you have to have approval of IRBs (institutional

review boards)?¹⁴ An excellent question. Depending on the situation of your participants and your situation, conducting theoretical sampling may require further clearance with institutional committees. Biomedical models of experimentation may well guide these committees. Through their decisions, they attempt to enact principles of doing no harm to research subjects, anticipating potential harm, and articulating strategies for minimizing and handling whatever harm arises. Funded research proposals receive careful scrutiny before their principal investigators can gather any data. Most researchers and students who pursue unfunded research also must receive approval from institutional committees before proceeding with their studies. How can they reconcile the emergent process of doing grounded theory with institutional constraints on research?¹⁵

Given the current practices of institutional review committees, many qualitative researchers try to anticipate all possible contingencies and account for them in their research proposals. Taken literally, theoretical sampling poses obstacles because you cannot anticipate what your core categories will be beforehand. You can, however, create a rationale to justify using theoretical sampling later without explaining the logic of theoretical sampling or specifying core categories in advance. Just seek approval for a possible second and perhaps third set of interviews and observations from the start. It helps to include participant observation at interview and field sites as part of your methodological approach. Multiple interviews and observations give you access. A discourse of clarification and confirmation should then suffice to gain approval of your proposal. By delineating key grounded theory steps, you show how you plan to increase the conceptual precision of your emerging ideas and to focus your data-gathering to achieve this precision as you proceed. Thus, your later observations, interviews, cases, or other data are pinpointed to address conceptual issues. In short, building plans to return to the field settings and key 'informants' into your original proposal gives you some leeway to gather further data to develop properties of categories. Similarly, when you design an interview study, plans to conduct follow-up interviews on the major ideas will allow for theoretical sampling.

Adopting the language of member-checking in your research proposal may also help, as a large literature on member-checking has made it an accepted—and sometimes expected—practice. Although member-checking generally refers to taking ideas back to research participants for their confirmation, you can use return visits to gather material to elaborate your categories. Cheryl Albas and Dan Albas¹⁶ devised a clever method of checking and refining their categories late in their research. They explain their major categories to certain participants they have studied and then inquire whether and to what extent these categories fit each participant's experience. Albas and Albas observe the participant's expressions given in the conversation and those unwittingly given off. When a participant offers bland agreement with their analysis, Albas and Albas conclude that their categories have not penetrated the core of the participant's experience. Subsequently, Albas and Albas engage the participant in a discussion to generate new properties of a category or a range of categories. They report that they have gained some of their best data from this technique.

Alasuutari (1992, 1996) invokes a similar strategy but turns it inside out. Instead of aiming to discover what he might have overlooked or under-analyzed, as

Albas and Albas did, he confronts his research participants with their tacit actions. Thus, Alasuutari aims for what *they* have overlooked or understated. He speaks from the standpoint of the researcher when he points out that informants typically provide meaningful but partial interpretations. The researcher must dig deeper to develop a more complete explanation. Alasuutari's strategies for constructing this explanation resemble theoretical sampling. See how he brought his observations back to his informants:

In one particular conversation I raised the issue of why members were always so eager to compete for the title of heaviest drinker and at the same time to belittle the drinking of other members:

PA: Somehow I feel there's this feeling in this group that there's someone here who hasn't drunk as much as the others or who's been down and out for a shorter while than others, that you tend to belittle that person's drinking, that, you know that's nothing really, I drank a lot more than he did.

A: Where've you heard that?

PA: I have you know.

B: I see.

PA: Even during these sessions right here.

C: It's always better the sooner you have the sense to go and get help isn't it.

A: That's right.

C: The longer you drink the more stupid you are, there's no doubt about that.

PA: But do you brag about being more stupid?

C: You tend to color things a bit, like I've been drinking longer than you have. You've only been drinking for a year but I've been there two years. So the one who's been drinking a year realizes that this is the point where I need to go and get help for myself. I'm so stupid that I didn't have the sense to come and get help, I had to carry on. So this is how I describe the situation so that there you are, I'm a bit better, *I know these things*, a bit better.

When I raised this question, the members of the group first wanted to deny my interpretation, even though I had clear examples of these sorts of situations in my field notes. When at long last it is admitted that the phenomenon really exists, member C (in the italicized section of his speech) renders further support to my interpretation that the emphasis on the seriousness of one's earlier alcohol problems is associated with the respect that members show for practical experience. (1995: 170–171)

In this instance, Alasuutari offered his interpretation and pushed for a dialogue about it.⁷ He gained confirmation of his view then pushed further later in the same conversation. In my view, Alasuutari's effectiveness relied on dual sources: strong bonds with group members and solid data from which to speak. Strong bonds build trust and foster open conversations with research participants about

areas ordinarily left unspoken. Solid data ground the questions—*despite their provocative nature*. What might be a preconceived leading question by an unskilled observer can become an incisive strategy by a practiced ethnographer. Interestingly, Alasuutari did not take the men's support for his interpretation at face value. Rather he took it a few analytic steps further. He located his confirmed interpretation in the context of the group culture and concluded that it also reflected the group members' contradictory relationships with staff and lack of trust in professionals.

Saturating Theoretical Categories

When do you stop gathering data? What criteria do you use? The standard short grounded theory answer to the criteria question dictates: stop when your categories are 'saturated.' The longer answer is that categories are 'saturated' when gathering fresh data no longer sparks new theoretical insights, nor reveals new properties of your core theoretical categories.

Categories are 'saturated' when gathering fresh data no longer sparks new theoretical insights, nor reveals new properties of these core theoretical categories.

As implied above, grounded theory saturation is not the same as witnessing repetition of the same events or stories, although many qualitative researchers confuse saturation with repetition of described events, actions, and/or statements. The common use of the term saturation refers to nothing new happening. 'I kept finding the same patterns.'

In contrast, Glaser (2001) takes a more sophisticated view of saturation than implied by common research parlance.

Saturation is not seeing the same pattern over and over again. It is the conceptualization of comparisons of these incidents which yield different properties of the pattern, until no new properties of the pattern emerge. This yields the conceptual density that when integrated into hypotheses make up the body of the generated grounded theory with theoretical completeness. (p. 191)

Glaser's perspective on saturation forms the foundation for treating theoretical concepts in grounded theory. When you treat categories theoretically, you raise them to an abstract and general level while preserving their specific connections to the data from which you constructed these categories. When assessing whether you have saturated your categories, consider asking such questions as the following:

- Which comparisons do you make between data within and between categories?
- What sense do you make of these comparisons?
- Where do they lead you?
- How do your comparisons illuminate your theoretical categories?

- In what other directions, if any, do they take you?
- What new conceptual relationships, if any, might you see?

Grounded theory logic invokes saturation as the criterion to apply to your categories. As such, some grounded theorists (Glaser, 1992, 1998, 2001; Stern, 2001) argue that you keep sampling until your categories are saturated and that this logic supercedes sample size—which may be very small.

Other considerations may supercede sample size. Think about how your claims of saturation affect the credibility of your study. A small study with modest claims might allow proclaiming saturation early. Researchers who make hefty claims should be circumspect about the thoroughness of their data and the rigor of their analyses. A study of 25 interviews may suffice for certain small projects but invites skepticism when the author's claims are about, say, human nature or contradict established research.

Theoretical saturation is what grounded theorists aim for—or should aim for, according to the canons. Yet grounded theorists often invoke the term, 'saturation' uncritically. Disagreements arise about the meaning of saturation. As Janice Morse (1995) observes, researchers often proclaim saturation rather than prove that they have achieved it. Thus, like other qualitative approaches, the grounded theory approach shares the hazard of assuming that categories are saturated when they may not be.

The kinds of initial research questions and the analytic level of the subsequent categories matter. Mundane research questions may rapidly produce saturated but common or trivial categories. For example, a researcher who asks whether obese women experience stigma may find that all of her interviews indicate that they do and claim that her category of 'experiencing stigma' is saturated without beginning to analyze what stigma means and how it is enacted. Uncritical or limited analytic treatment may also result in early saturation of categories. Novel questions may demand more complex categories and more sustained inquiry.

Dey (1999) challenges the notion of saturation on two counts: the meaning of saturation and its consequences. First, he points out that grounded theorists produce categories through partial—not exhaustive—coding. Dey views the term 'saturation' as 'another unfortunate metaphor' (p. 257) because of its imprecise usage. For him, the term saturation is incongruent with a procedure that 'stops short of coding all of the data' (p. 257) and relies on the researcher's *conjecture* that the properties of the category are saturated. In short, you cannot produce evidence to support this conjecture without doing the work. Rather than establishing categories saturated by data, Dey contends that we have categories *suggested* by data. Instead of claims of achieving saturation, Dey's preferred term, '*theoretical sufficiency*' (p. 257), better fits how researchers conduct grounded theory.

Second, Dey implies that following grounded theory methods may lead to unanticipated consequences for saturating categories. He wonders if saturation of categories itself is an artifact of how grounded theorists focus and manage data collection. Such concerns spark further questions. Are our claims to having saturated categories legitimate? If so, when? Is the method a teleological closed system? When researchers treat grounded theory guidelines like recipes,

they do foreclose possibilities for innovation without having explored their data. Strauss and Corbin's (1990, 1998) axial coding matrix may force data into preconceived frameworks, as any set of Glaser's theoretical codes may also. Adopting and applying these frameworks takes the focusing inherent in grounded theory and renders it directive and prescriptive. Subsequently, researchers undermine the value and legitimacy of their analyses.

By extension, Dey's argument complements my concerns about foreclosing analytic possibilities and about constructing superficial analyses. My solution? Be open to what is happening in the field and be willing to grapple with it. When you get stuck, go back and recode earlier data and see if you define new leads. Use grounded theory guidelines to give *you* a handle on the material, not a machine that does the work for you.

Theoretical Sorting, Diagramming, and Integrating

Sorting, diagramming, and integrating your memos are inter-related processes. Your sorting may integrate the analysis and a diagram may simultaneously sort and integrate it. The visual image of a diagram may suggest the content and direction of the analysis as well as its form. All qualitative researchers use such methodological strategies as sorting, diagramming, and integrating their materials; however, grounded theorists use these strategies in service of the *theoretical* development of their analysis. I treat sorting, diagramming, and integrating separately below for clarity although they are intertwined in grounded theory practice.

Theoretical Sorting

Analytic memos provide the substance for creating first drafts of papers or chapters. Writing memos during each analytic phase prompts you to make the analysis progressively stronger, clearer, and more theoretical. You already have developed categories in your written memos and have titled them in as concrete, specific, and analytic terms as possible. Now you are ready to sort them.

In grounded theory, sorting goes beyond the first step in organizing a paper, chapter, or book: sorting serves your emerging theory. It gives you a means of creating and refining theoretical links. Through sorting, you work on the theoretical integration of your categories. Thus, sorting prompts you to compare categories at an abstract level.

Think of the logic of your emerging theory. It became apparent in my research on the experience of chronic illness that certain events reverberated in people's consciousness long after their occurrence and became turning points. I called them 'significant events' and treated them as a major category because they shaped meanings of time and self. My treatment¹⁸ of the category reads:

Grounded theory sorting gives you a logic for organizing your analysis and a way of creating and refining theoretical links that prompts you to make comparisons between categories.

Significant Events as Turning Points

Relived moments. Retold stories ... recurring feelings. Significant events echo in memory. Whether validating or wholly disrupting, a significant event reveals images of present or possible self and evokes feelings. Thus, these events mark time and become turning points.

A significant event stands out in memory because it has boundaries, intensity, and emotional force. Furthermore, a significant event captures, demarks, and intensifies feelings. Frequently, those feelings are unhappy ones such as bewilderment, humiliation, shame, betrayal, or loss. The event flames and frames these feelings. The emotional reverberations of a single event echo through the present and future and therefore, however subtly, shade thoughts and feelings about self and alter meanings of time (cf. Denzin, 1984).

Significant events transcend the actors within them and the stage on which they occur. These events are emergent realities, events *sui generis*; they cannot be reduced to component parts (Durkheim, 1951). Thus, a significant event reflects more than a relationship or another's actions. When, where, and how the event occurs, and who participates in it, contribute to the force of the event and affect subsequent interpretations of it. Sorting what the event means and the 'correct' feelings to hold about it shapes self-images and self-worth.

A significant event freezes and enlarges a moment in time. Because of inherent or potential meanings of self within the event, people grant obdurate qualities to it. They reify it. To them, the event supercedes past meanings and foretells future selves. (Charmaz, 1991a: 210)

In the narrative above, I spelled out the properties of the category. Then I addressed two processes subsumed by it: finding positive events and reliving negative events. When research participants defined specific positive or negative events as turning points that held meaning for self, I treated them as significant events. Next I considered how a person's present emotions were tied to a past self. In this case, sorting proceeded from a straightforward logic but became more complex as I brought the analysis from past to present with memos about subcategories of 'experiencing present emotions and a past self' and 'transcending past emotions.'

Researchers construct how they sort and compile memos. The closer your sorting reflects your depiction of the flow of empirical experience, the smoother it will seem to you and likely to your readers. When you have a logic that makes sense, sorting and integrating memos falls into place. When you include several processes or pursue multiple categories, how to sort and integrate your memos may not always be so clear-cut. Try several different sortings and think through how each portrays your analysis. When you are working out the implications of each way of sorting, it may help to diagram them.

Sorting, comparing, and integrating memos seem like simple steps. Each memo on a category may become a section or subsection of the draft. If so, integrating memos may merely reproduce the theoretical logic of the analysis, or stages of a process. However, sorting, comparing, and integrating memos may be more

complicated. Take a memo from your pile and compare it with another, then another (see also Glaser, 1998). How do the memos compare? Does your comparison spark new ideas? If so write another memo. Do you discern new relationships between memos? What leads do you gain by sorting the memos? If it helps, take your related memos and form quick clusters with them. How do they fit together? What makes most sense? Some sets of memos fit together so well that the answers seem obvious. But for many analyses, you must create the order and make the connections for your readers. The first draft of your paper represents how you sort, compare, and integrate a set of memos into some kind of coherent order.

How does one go about sorting, comparing, and integrating memos?

- Sort memos by the title of each category
- Compare categories
- Use your categories—carefully
- Consider how their order reflects the studied experience
- Now think how their order fits the logic of the categories
- Create the best possible balance between the studied experience, your categories, and your theoretical statements about them.

Some practical advice may help. Sort your memos by hand in an area where you can see and shuffle them. Turn the computer off for now. A large table works well; the floor can too if you have no cats or children to disrupt your sorted designs. I once plastered my dining room walls with cards containing the titles of my memos. Be willing to experiment with different arrangements of your memos. Treat these arrangements as tentative and play with them. Lay out your memos in several different ways. Draw a few diagrams to connect them. When you create a sorting that looks promising, jot it down and diagram it.

Continue to compare categories while you sort memos. Sorting fosters your efforts to refine comparisons between categories. As a result of sorting, you can see relationships between your categories more clearly. For example, sorting memos about time and self, clarified a major shift in how people with serious chronic illnesses viewed themselves. I saw how easily they went from trying to live in the present to situating their selves in the past as the present became more problematic. Relationships between categories form an outline of what you cover and *how* you cover it. They give your future readers important information. And studying and sorting these categories helps you learn when and where you go astray.

Diagramming

Diagrams can offer concrete images of our ideas. The advantage of diagrams is that they provide a visual representation of categories and their relationships. Many grounded theorists, particularly those influenced by Clarke (2003, 2005), Strauss (1987) and Strauss and Corbin (1998), treat creating visual images of their emerging theories as an intrinsic part of grounded theory methods. They use various types of diagrams—including maps, charts, and figures—to tease out relationships while constructing their analyses and to demonstrate these relationships in their completed works.

Diagrams can enable you to see the relative power, scope, and direction of the categories in your analysis as well as the connections among them. You may find that diagrams can serve useful and diverse purposes at all stages of analysis. You might revise an early quick clustering about a category into a more exacting form as a diagram illustrating the properties of a category. You might develop a conceptual map that locates your concepts and directs movement between them.

Maps show positions and processes (Clarke, 2003, 2005). Conceptual maps can plot the relative strength or weakness of relationships. Adele Clarke (2003, 2005) uses maps to create sophisticated situational analyses that offer a fresh alternative to the earlier grounded theory emphasis on basic social processes. She argues that we already know much about our research sites and problems before officially collecting data and that maps are one way to make fruitful use of this knowledge.

Through mapping situations, social worlds and their arenas, and positions in discourses, Clarke intends to develop grounded theory methods in ways that preserve empirical realities and complexities without resorting to reductionist analyses or wholly relying on the basic social process model that Glaser (1978) long argued was essential to grounded theory. Consider Clarke's techniques (see Figures 5.1 and 5.2) for sorting conventional grounded theory memos in addition to explicating the social arenas and social worlds' levels of analysis for which she devised them.

Clarke's situational maps take Glaser's (1998) dictum 'All is data' seriously because she builds structural properties right into her maps and positions them in social worlds and arenas. The structural elements that shape and condition the situation being studied can be plotted on the map. Her strategy allows us to move from micro to organizational levels of analysis and to render invisible structural relationships and processes visible. Similarly, this approach fosters making relationships and processes between different social worlds and arenas visible that ordinarily might be hidden from view. The situational analysis that follows provides provisional, flexible, interpretive theorizing about the construction of the studied social worlds.

Strauss and Corbin (1990, 1998) introduce the conditional/consequential matrix as a way of providing a visual representation of the observed transactions in the empirical world and their interactions and inter-relationships. In particular, they offer this matrix as an analytic device for thinking about macro and micro relationships that might shape the situations the researcher studies. They provide a depiction of the conditional/consequential matrix as concentric but connected circles that place the individual at the core in their 1998 edition (as contrasted with placing action at the core in the 1990 edition). The concentric circles represent increasingly larger social units.

A major purpose of the conditional/consequential matrix is to help researchers to think beyond micro social structures and immediate interactions to larger social conditions and consequences. Strauss and Corbin propose that the conditional/consequential matrix can aid researchers in making theoretical sampling decisions as well as in locating the contexts in which the conditions occur and the paths between them. They present this matrix as offering a means for developing theory that advances the researcher's work beyond describing phenomena. The conditional/consequential matrix is a technique to *apply*; therefore, it may force

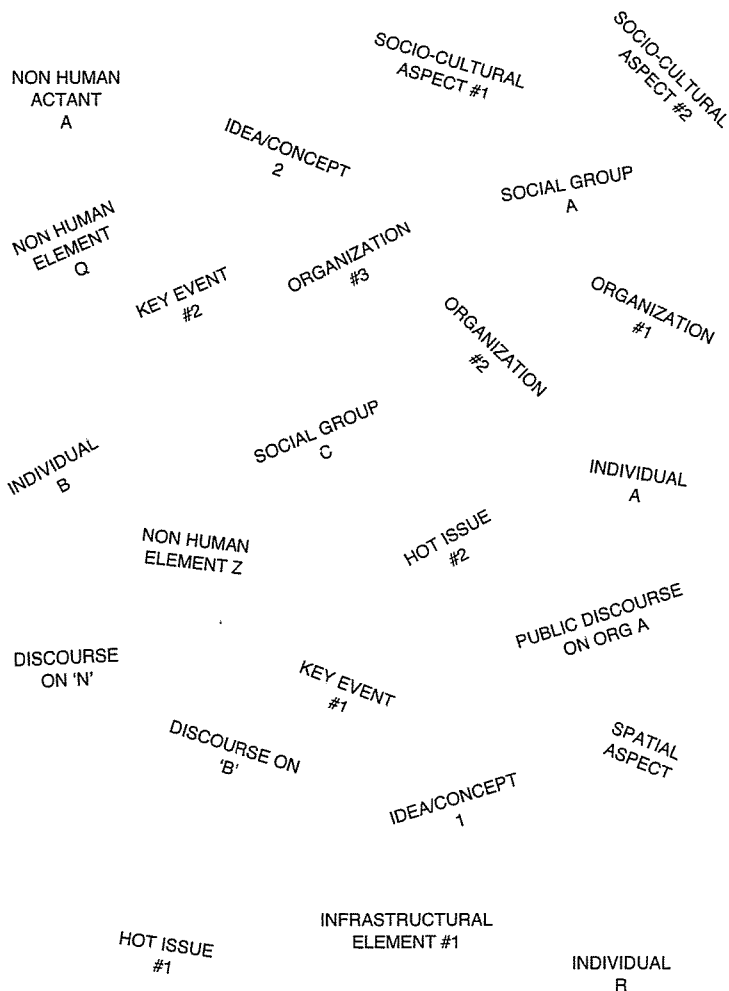


FIGURE 5.1 Abstract Situational Map, Messy Working Version

Source: Clarke, 2003: 564. © 2003 by the Society for the Study of Symbolic Interaction. Used with permission.

moving your data and analysis in a pre-established direction. If, however, your emerging analysis indicates that mapping conditions, contexts, and consequences in this way fits your data, you might wish to use this matrix.

Integrating Memos

How do you integrate the memos? Ordering for process is one obvious solution to integrate the piece. If you build your paper on a major category, then you must decide how the memos about it best fit together. Processual analyses have a

HUMAN ELEMENTS/ACTORS e.g., individuals collective actors specific organizations	NON HUMAN ELEMENTS e.g., technologies material infrastructure specialized knowledges material 'things'
POLITICAL/ECONOMIC ASPECTS e.g., the state particular industry/ies local/regional/global orders political parties	SOCIO-CULTURAL ASPECTS e.g., mass media religion ethnicity race
TEMPORAL DIMENSIONS e.g., historic aspects seasonal aspects crisis aspects	SPATIAL DIMENSIONS e.g., geography
DISCURSIVE CONSTRUCTION(S) OF NON HUMAN ACTANTS As found in the situation	DISCURSIVE CONSTRUCTION OF HUMAN ACTORS As found in the situation
MAJOR ISSUES/DEBATES [USUALLY CONTESTED] As found in the situation, and see positional map	MORE SYMBOLIC DIMENSIONS e.g., aesthetic elements affective/sentimental elements moral/ethical elements
OTHER KINDS OF ELEMENTS As found in the situation	DISCOURSES e.g., normative expectations of actors, actants, and/or other particular elements; popular cultural discourses; situation-specific discourses

FIGURE 5.2 Abstract Situational Map, Ordered Working Version

Source: Clarke, 2003: 564. © 2003 by the Society for the Study of Symbolic Interaction. Used with permission.

built-in logical order, but analytic categories may have a subtle one that will make sense to your readers. For example, in my analysis of disclosure, it made sense to talk first about avoiding disclosure of illness followed by assessing the risks and then disclosing illness. Taking this example into another realm, avoiding and risk-ing disclosures—personal, professional, and organizational disclosures—occur in work settings of all kinds. A corporate manager who knows that downsizing lies on the horizon may first avoid disclosure, and then risk it with trusted staff, and later make strategic general announcements. In this case, disclosure dilemmas relate to the type and extent of public release of information or potential discoveries of hidden information, and other conditions that affect disclosure.

Much of the grounded theory literature emphasizes writing about a single category. You may, however, need to juggle several categories. If so, then your sorting attends to how these categories fit—or do not fit—together. The subsequent integration may reflect what you found in the empirical world. The integration makes relationships intelligible. Early grounded theory studies stressed causal relationships but now many scholars aim for interpretive understandings. Such understandings remain contingent on contextual conditions.

Through sorting and integrating memos, you may explicate implicit theoretical codes which you may have adopted without realizing it. In addition, these strategies may force you to think through theoretical links among categories that may have been left implicit. Diagramming sharpens the relationships among your theoretical categories. All three strategies can spark ideas for constructing your written report and shaping the introduction and writing the theoretical framework.

Concluding Thoughts

Like coding and memo-writing, theoretical sampling occupies a crucial place in grounded theory. It articulates a practice that the best qualitative researchers may follow but may not define. The movement back and forth between category and data in theoretical sampling fosters raising the conceptual level of your categories and extending their reach. As you develop your categories, you can see which ones to treat as major concepts in your analysis.

By engaging in theoretical sampling, saturation, and sorting, you create robust categories and penetrating analyses. Capturing what you have gained in successively more abstract memos gives you the grist for the first draft of your finished piece. Sorting and diagramming gives you its initial analytic frame. Now you are ready to write the first draft of your report but first you may wish to think a bit more about theorizing in grounded theory.

NOTES

- 1 Strauss (see Strauss, 1987; Strauss & Corbin, 1990, 1998) emphasized diagramming as a way of laying out conceptual relationships. Since then, this approach is most developed in Adele Clarke's (2003, 2005) works. As a graduate student, I wrote a paper, 'Conceptual Mapping' (1969), that addressed ways to integrate theoretical analyses by showing relationships between concepts and by offering a visual representation of their relative significance.
- 2 Interview with Jane Hood, November 12, 2004.
- 3 Hood's use of theoretical sampling built directly on grounded theory guidelines; however, her coding strategies diverged. She began coding with open-ended codes and quickly went to a formal procedure with code sheets to sort and organize the material into more general categories (see 1983: 200–202). Hood stated that she might have done something different had she had access to something like The Ethnograph, a computer-assisted program. She said that she used the code sheet approach as a way of 'interviewing' her data and holding herself accountable for patterns in the data as well as to check properties of categories. Although the code sheets may look like survey coding, she said that she was not using survey coding because the point was not to count but to establish category boundaries. Social scientists frequently draw on several methodological approaches simultaneously, depending on the research problem and/or the researcher's proclivities. Some nurse researchers disdain such methodological ecumenicalism as method slurring (see Baker, Wuest, & Stern, 1992).
- 4 Should customer service representatives define your presence as a management plant, they will likely conceal their concerns and perhaps their usual practices. Moreover, they may see you and your research as an extension of organizational forms of domination consistent with Dorothy E. Smith's (1999) warnings about researchers reproducing domination that participants already experience in the setting. If they see you as an ally, then you may gain a different picture, and gain still another view on the scene if you talk with customers about their experiences.

- 5 Doctoral students might negotiate with their advisors by building several stages of data collection into their research proposals. That way, they could begin by taking population distributions into account but plan to follow the leads in their emerging analyses thereafter.
- 6 Jane Hood edited this passage for clarity.
- 7 Fiction can provide great data for all kinds of projects when researchers treat them as texts to analyze, rather than as substitute realities. For example, we could look at how authors represent women and men, collective values, or individual quests during specific time periods. Hypothetical negative cases are trickier. The extent of researchers' knowledge about their studied worlds and how they use these cases matters here. Superficial knowledge and scant further inquiry can derail a grounded theory analysis. Researchers who rely on hypothetical negative cases risk slipping into armchair theorizing.
- 8 Charles Sanders Peirce (1878 [1958]) developed abductive reasoning. It underlies the pragmatist tradition of problem-solving and supports the notion that the borders between scientific discovery and justification are indistinct. Strauss was heavily influenced by Peirce and John Dewey as well as George Herbert Mead. The creative, cognitive dimensions of abductive reasoning in grounded theory may be most emphasized by Strauss and his followers.
- 9 As I pointed out in earlier chapters, you can revisit and recode earlier data from the vantage point of a new idea, which expedites theoretical sampling of your new category.
- 10 I chose to make experiencing illness the focus of the book because it would speak to broader audiences than a book on time. This focus did, however, allow developing the analyses of time and self.
- 11 For a study in which married women in middle-class dual-earner families took the lead in time negotiations and indirectly maintained control over family tasks, see Kerry Daly (2002). The couples worked in managerial or professional positions for fifty hours a week or more. Daly found that by controlling the family schedule, these women obtained their husbands' participation in childcare and household work.
- 12 Gubrium (1993) has observed that nursing home residents similarly locate themselves in time. While some saw their lives as in the past, others were rooted in their nursing-home experience, and still others looked over their current situations to the future.
- 13 I developed these subcategories from depictions of my participants' statements and actions. Hence they import fewer implied judgments than the psychological concepts of acceptance and denial that pervade professionals' discourse about illness and impairment.
- 14 Her question arose during a presentation titled, 'Constructing Qualitative Research through Grounded Theory,' at the Center for AIDS Prevention Studies (CAPS), University of California, San Francisco, September 7, 2004.
- 15 Qualitative researchers in a number of disciplines and professions are challenging narrow institutional directives that hinder their research. They are engaged in educating colleagues who adhere to a biomedical model about its limitations for qualitative research. Changes in ethics policies and institutional reviews should result.
- 16 Personal communication, March 29, 2004. Albas and Albas found that they obtained some of their most compelling data with this method and, simultaneously, they expedited and strengthened their analyses. See also, D. Albas & C. Albas (1988, 1993) and C. Albas & D. Albas (1988).
- 17 Alasuutari's strategy is reminiscent of advice that Anselm Strauss once gave me about not taking textbook prescriptions of conducting neutral interviews too seriously. He found that sometimes provocative questions worked and field researchers could ask them, as long as they did not get kicked out of the setting.
- 18 The copy editor changed my final wording about relived moments and recurring feelings without consulting me. My original rendering is included here.

6

Reconstructing Theory in Grounded Theory Studies

Grounded theorists talk much about theory and about constructing theory, but what do they mean? In this chapter, we stop for a sojourn to contemplate what theory means and how grounded theorists engage in theorizing as a *practice*. I begin with an excerpt of theorizing in grounded theory research and then step back and ask: What is theory? By viewing general definitions of theory as two distinct traditions, we clarify how the antecedents of constructivist and objectivist grounded theory reflect these traditions. Reconsidering critiques of grounded theory helps to refresh our thinking and reaffirm our theoretical tasks. To encourage your development of theoretical sensitivity, I suggest ways you might plumb the depth of your ideas while expanding the reach of your theory. We close by inspecting how three different grounded theories demonstrate theorizing in practice and end by reflecting on how grounded theorists are part of their theorizing.

What stands as *theory* in grounded theory? How do researchers make their grounded theory analyses theoretical; that is, how do they move from the process of analysis to production of a grounded theory? Which directions do grounded theories typically take? To assess if, how, why, and when grounded theory studies offer 'bona fide' theories, requires taking a step back and asking: What is theory? The term theory remains slippery in grounded theory discourse. Many grounded theorists talk about theory but few define it. A number of grounded theorists claim they construct theory, but do they? A closer look may help. By taking several grounded theories apart, I will reconstruct their logic with you.

To begin thinking about reconstructing theory in grounded theory research, consider the excerpt below from my study of the experience of chronic illness. It is part of a paper that contains an explicit theoretical logic. In the analysis, I focused on how people with serious chronic illnesses struggled to have a valued self.¹ They struggled with both how they defined themselves and how other people identified them. I realized that people who suffered physical losses developed identity goals for their future, particularly when their losses occurred during a short period of time. I grappled with these sometimes overt, but often

covert, meanings and implications of identity goals to develop a theoretical rendering. A number of people planned to struggle against illness and to compete in conventional worlds. They espoused these goals when illness and disability were new. As time elapsed, they usually scaled down their identity goals. The short excerpt below captures the logic of my substantive theory of relationships between identity goals and the emerging identity hierarchy.

An identity hierarchy becomes visible as ill people, over time, choose different types of preferred identities, reflecting relative difficulty in achieving specific aspirations and objectives. The types of preferred identities constitute particular identity levels in the identity hierarchy. These identity levels include: (1) the supernormal social identity, an identity demanding extraordinary achievement in conventional worlds; (2) the restored self, a reconstruction of previous identities before illness; (3) contingent personal identity, a hypothetically possible, though uncertain, identity because of further illness; and (4) the salvaged self, retaining a past identity based on a valued activity or attribute while becoming physically dependent. Experiencing progressive illness often means reducing identity goals and aiming for a lower level in the identity hierarchy. In short, reducing identity goals means aiming for a less preferred identity. (Charmaz, 1987: 285)

In the narrative, I point out that my research participants struggled for a valued self because they did not want to be invalids. For them, being an invalid meant being an invalid person. This assumption informed the identity goals they made and the actions they took. An important property of the identity hierarchy concerns movement in it. People do not always plummet down the identity hierarchy; some climb up identity levels. I observed a few people with serious illnesses without much hope, move from being immersed in illness to realizing extraordinary accomplishments. They may start from different points, depending on how they define their situations, and they may move up and down the identity hierarchy through the course of their illness.

Part of my task involved accounting for these chronically ill people's identity goals and the actions they took, if any, to realize them. Hence, I aimed to fulfill the following objectives: 1) to develop the properties of each category in the identity hierarchy and demonstrate how they fit together; 2) to specify conditions under which my research participants selected a preferred identity; 3) to take into account the resources they could pull together to realize their identity goals; 4) to define when they moved up or down the identity hierarchy; 5) to delineate social contexts in which they attempted to negotiate and establish their preferred and potential identities; and 6) to suggest how different identity levels presuppose different selves. These analytic objectives contributed to the theoretical level and density of the analysis. See how I began to weave them into the paper:

The person's *expectations of and for self* are significant sources of his or her definitions of preferred identities for the future. People maintain self consistency and continuity through their expectations as well as their actions. Age alone affects such expectations. Younger adults confront all the usual identity issues of their age cohorts clustering around career,

intimacy, and lifestyle. These young adults typically made valiant efforts to realize their preferred identities. Profoundly disturbed by the threat of a life of invalidism, they also thought it unsuitable for persons their age. Many others echo this woman's remark: 'I expected to have a chronic illness which interfered with my life at seventy-five, but at twenty-nine? Who would have guessed it?' (p. 292)

My analysis of movement up and down the identity hierarchy takes a neutral, objective tone in presenting the ideas and their relationships. These excerpts obscure the constructivism in my analysis, which since then has become more visible in my work. My neutral writing style above separates my ideas about the identity hierarchy from their analytic construction but links them as theoretical conceptions. The neutral tones of analytic discourse in much qualitative research erase the interpretive acts that produced them and, moreover, eradicate ambiguities in both the studied scenes and their analytic treatment (Charmaz & Mitchell, 1996).

Now we need to interrogate the excerpts above and ask what makes the line of analysis in them theory—or theoretical. What kind of presuppositions about theory does this type of analysis assume? How can we reconcile the creative process of developing grounded theories with their objectivist presentations in theoretical reports? How might we take grounded theory in a constructionist direction? To make theorizing transparent, we need to see how grounded theorists construct their theories.

What Is Theory?

What does 'theory' mean in social scientific thinking? What should stand as a bona fide theory exemplifying a grounded theory? Disagreements about how to do grounded theory and what a completed theory should look like often arise from unsettled notions about what theory means. These disagreements resonate with grumblings—and ideological clashes—throughout the social sciences that grounded theorists echo without necessarily realizing their epistemological underpinnings. Such disagreements may be played out and intensified in discussions and directions about how to construct grounded theory. When we look beneath the surface, we can discern different meanings of theory among grounded theorists. Some of these definitions of theory remain firm, some are elastic.

When thinking about concepts of theory in grounded theory, it helps to look at broader definitions of theory in the social sciences. I touch upon theoretical perspectives in classical sociological theory and cultural studies to exemplify these broader definitions and to identify major themes in them.

Positivist Definitions of Theory

Perhaps the most prevalent definitions of theory derive from positivism. Positivist definitions of theory treat it as a statement of relationships between abstract concepts that cover a wide range of empirical observations. Positivists view their theoretical concepts as variables and construct operational definitions of their

concepts for hypothesis testing through accurate, replicable empirical measurement. These definitions exert considerable influence for two reasons: 1) they reach across fields and 2) authors of research textbooks widely adopt and promulgate them.

In this view, the objectives of theory are *explanation* and *prediction*. Positivist theory aims for parsimony, generality, and universality and simultaneously reduces empirical objects and events to that which can be subsumed by the concepts. Positivist theory seeks causes, favors deterministic explanations, and emphasizes generality and universality. In short, positivist theories consist of a set of inter-related propositions aimed to:

Positivist theory seeks causes, favors deterministic explanations, and emphasizes generality and universality.

- Treat concepts as variables
- Specify relationships between concepts
- Explain and predict these relationships
- Systematize knowledge
- Verify theoretical relationships through hypothesis-testing
- Generate hypotheses for research.

With their emphasis on parsimony, these theories are elegant in form and direct in their statements; however, these theories can result in narrow, reductionist explanations with simplistic models of action.

Interpretive Definitions of Theory

An alternative definition of theory emphasizes *understanding* rather than explanation. Proponents of this definition view theoretical understanding as abstract and interpretive; the very understanding gained from the theory rests on the theorist's interpretation of the studied phenomenon. Interpretive theories allow for indeterminacy rather than seek causality and give priority to showing patterns and connections rather than to linear reasoning. George Ritzer and Douglas J. Goodman's (2004) discussion of criteria for classical sociological theory (which assumes abstract, general concepts) illustrates this view. For Ritzer and Goodman, theory has a far-ranging scope, offers wide applications, and deals with fundamental issues in social life.

Given their focus on classical theory, it has also withstood the test of time. They declare that their definition contrasts with theories that aim for explanation and prediction. Ritzer and Goodman's definition of theory has strong interpretive elements in its emphasis on understanding and scope.

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Interpretive theory calls for the imaginative understanding of the studied phenomenon. This type of theory assumes emergent, multiple realities; indeterminacy; facts and values as linked; truth as provisional; and social life as processual.

inextricably linked; truth as provisional; and social life as processual. Thus interpretive theory is fully compatible with George Herbert Mead's symbolic interactionism, which shares these assumptions. Mead takes a sophisticated view of action as the starting place for analysis that includes the person's imagined understanding of the other person's role and response during interaction.

We interpret our participants' meanings and actions and they interpret ours. The interpretive turn in theory has gained attention as social constructionist principles gained advocates among diverse scholars, particularly since the 1960s. This theoretical approach emphasizes practices and actions. Rather than explaining reality, social constructionists see multiple realities and therefore ask: *What* do people assume is real? *How* do they construct and act on their view of reality? Thus knowledge—and theories—are situated and located in particular positions, perspectives, and experiences. In brief, interpretive theory aims to:

- Conceptualize the studied phenomenon to understand it in abstract terms
- Articulate theoretical claims pertaining to scope, depth, power, and relevance
- Acknowledge subjectivity in theorizing and hence the role of negotiation, dialogue, understanding
- Offer an imaginative interpretation.

Interpretive theories are often juxtaposed against positivist theories, which I do below in my discussion of constructivist and objectivist grounded theory. For now, consider that grounded theory as *theory* contains both positivist and interpretivist inclinations. Glaser's (1978, 1992, 1998, 2003) treatment of theory contains strong positivist leanings. He emphasizes the development of theoretical categories that serve as variables, assumes an indicator-concept approach, seeks context-free but modifiable theoretical statements, and aims for 'the achievement of parsimony and scope in explanatory power' (1992: 116). Glaser stresses the work of using comparative methods and attributes the analytic development of theory to emergence from this comparative work; however, he treats emergent categories almost as its automatic result. The place of interpretive understanding remains less clear in his position than the positivist elements.

Strauss and Corbin's (1998) view of theory has some positivist leanings but emphasizes relationships among concepts. For them, theory means 'a set of well-developed concepts related through statements of relationship, which together constitute an integrated framework that can be used to explain or predict phenomena' (p. 15). Their stance toward constructing theories, however, also acknowledges interpretivist views. Corbin (1998) recognizes that analysis means that researchers interpret data but implies that such interpretation is an unavoidable limitation. She writes, 'How can one remove who and what one is from the comparative process? An analyst can only compare based on how s/he reads the data. One would hope that by 'sticking to the data' the analyst is left out of the interpretive process, but this is highly unlikely' (p. 123). Strauss and Corbin draw clear distinctions between theory and description, which they see as a person's use of words to invoke mental images of objects, events, and experiences. For them, theory is much more abstract and explanatory.

If we turn to cultural theory, Alasuutari (1996) further distinguishes between how lay people ordinarily make sense of their worlds and what the concept of theory means. By adopting a sophisticated view of theory consistent with Schutz (1967), Alasuutari argues that theoreticians examine lay persons' rules of interpretation and therefore move beyond lay persons' conceptions.

One takes a one-step distance from the members' perspective, not by arguing that it is narrower or incorrect, but by studying how it works in constituting social realities. Theories are thus deconstructions of the way in which we construct realities and social conditions and ourselves as subjects in those realities. They cannot compete with lay thinking, because their very objective is to make sense of it in its various forms and in different instances. (1996: 382)

Alasuutari explicitly departs from definitions of theory as generalized statements about universals from which researchers deduce hypotheses to explain local, specific phenomena. Instead, to him theories provide interpretive *frames* from which to view realities. Although Alasuutari's comment recognizes that lay persons and researchers hold different interpretive frames, we might note that both make sense of lay persons' ideas and actions.

Alasuutari's careful explication of the local scenes and specific incidents combined with his theorizing of them gives his work theoretical reach and depth. His work combines the sensibilities of a skilled ethnographer with the kind of theoretical sensitivity possessed by the best grounded theorists.

The Rhetoric, Reach, and Practice of Theorizing

Whether positivist or interpretive, theories are rhetorical—although interpretive theorists more likely acknowledge this point than their positivist counterparts. A theorist attempts to convince readers that certain conclusions flow from a set of premises (Markovsky, 2004). Thus, theories present arguments about the world and relationships within it, despite sometimes being cleansed of context and reduced to seemingly neutral statements. For those who espouse positivist notions of objectivity, such cleansing and neutrality only adds to their persuasiveness.

When we consider either positivist or interpretive theory, we need to think of its theoretical reach and power within, beyond, and between disciplines. Randall Collins says, 'Theory is what you remember' (2004a; see also Davis, 1971). Theories flash illuminating insights and make sense of murky musings and knotty problems. The ideas fit. Phenomena and relationships between them you only sensed beforehand become visible. Still, theories can do more. A theory can alter your viewpoint and change your consciousness. Through it, you can see the world from a different vantage point and create new meanings of it. Theories have an internal logic and more or less coalesce into coherent forms.

My preference for theorizing—and it is for theorizing, not theory—is unabashedly interpretive. Theorizing is a *practice*. It entails the practical activity of engaging the world and of constructing abstract understandings about and within it. The fundamental contribution of grounded theory methods resides in

offering a guide to interpretive theoretical practice not in providing a blueprint for theoretical products.

Interpretive theorizing arises from social constructionist assumptions that inform symbolic interaction, ethnomethodology, cultural studies and phenomenological discourse, and narrative analysis. Such theorizing is not limited to individual actors or micro situations. Nor should it be. Rather, interpretive theorizing can move beyond individual situations and immediate interactions. Maines (2001) makes this argument about symbolic interactionism and Alasuutari's (1995, 1996, 2004) vantage point in cultural studies points a way. Speaking from the theorists' camp, Collins (2004b) argues for situations rather than individuals as starting points for theorizing continuities between classical nineteenth-century theory and contemporary theoretical questions. He views the social in the individual and explores how the varied intensity of rituals shape forms of social participation and ideas at local levels that collectively involve larger social structures. Strauss's analyses of negotiated orders (1978; Strauss, Schatzman, Bucher, Ehrlich, & Sabshin, 1963) and social worlds (1978a) initiate interpretive inquiry at organizational and collective levels. Rather than studying the structure of the hospital as static, Strauss and his colleagues (1963) revealed its dynamic, processual nature by analyzing negotiations within and between people and departments at varied organizational levels in the hospital. Their interpretation of the hospital as a negotiated order and analysis of this order assumed considerable significance because Strauss et al. showed how researchers could study the construction of individual and collective action and the intersections between them.

Interpretive theorizing can infuse network analysis with the tools to bring meanings into view. Both Collins (2004b) and Clarke (2003, 2005) suggest methodological strategies for studying meso and macro levels of analysis. Collins endorses using network analysis to study situations, although grounded theorists would find that Clarke's methods give them more access to specific contexts and types of interactions. When researchers use both methods, they may find that Clarke's situational analysis and positional mapping can broaden network analysis and make it more interpretive.

Constructivist and Objectivist Grounded Theory

Throughout this book, I have treated using grounded theory methods and theorizing as *social actions* that researchers construct in concert with others in particular places and times. In addition to our research participants, colleagues, teachers, students, institutional committees and untold others may live in our minds and influence how we conduct our studies long after our immediate contact with them. We interact with data and create theories about it. But we do not exist in a social vacuum.

How might our conceptions of theory and research influence what we do and the allegiances we hold? As I have implied, a number of the disputes among grounded theorists and critiques by other colleagues result from where various authors stand between interpretive and positivist traditions.

I have explicated those differences by arguing that grounded theory has taken somewhat different forms since its creation: constructivist and objectivist grounded theory (Charmaz, 2000, 2001). Constructivist grounded theory is part of the interpretive tradition and objectivist grounded theory derives from positivism. I juxtapose these forms here for clarity; however, whether you

I juxtapose constructivist and objectivist forms of grounded theory here for clarity; however, whether you judge a specific study to be constructivist or objectivist depends on the *extent* to which its key characteristics conform to one tradition or the other.

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Constructivist Grounded Theory

As consistent with my stance in earlier chapters, a constructivist approach places priority on the phenomena of study and sees both data and analysis as created from shared experiences and relationships with participants and other sources of data (see Charmaz, 1990, 1995b, 2000, 2001; Charmaz & Mitchell, 1996). Constructivist grounded theory lies squarely in the interpretive tradition.

A constructivist approach places priority on the phenomena of study and sees both data and analysis as created from shared experiences and relationships with participants (see Charmaz, 1990, 1995b, 2000, 2001; Charmaz & Mitchell, 1996).

Constructivists study *how*—and sometimes *why*—participants construct meanings and actions in specific situations. As I explained in Chapter 2, we do so from as close to the inside of the experience as we can get but realize that we cannot replicate the experi-

ences of our research participants. A constructivist approach means more than looking at how individuals view their situations. It not only theorizes the interpretive work that research participants do, but also acknowledges that the resulting theory is an interpretation (Bryant, 2002; Charmaz, 2000, 2002a). The theory *depends* on the researcher's view; it does not and cannot stand outside of it. Granted, different researchers may come up with similar ideas, although how they render them theoretically may differ.

Grounded theorists may borrow an insight from Silverman's (2004) observation of conversational analysis. He contends that only after establishing how people construct meanings and actions can the analyst pursue why they act as they do. Certainly a fine-grained analysis of how people construct actions and meanings can lead a grounded theorist to establishing some reasons for it, although occasionally the why may emerge with the how.

The logical extension of the constructivist approach means learning how, when, and to what extent the studied experience is embedded in larger and, often, hidden positions, networks, situations, and relationships. Subsequently, differences and distinctions between people become visible as well as the hierarchies of power, communication, and opportunity that maintain and perpetuate such

differences and distinctions. A constructivist approach means being alert to conditions under which such differences and distinctions arise and are maintained. Having the material to anchor the experience takes rich data and entails having sufficient knowledge so one can see differences and distinctions. When grounded theory studies are extremely small, they risk being disconnected from their social contexts and situations. Thus, researchers can diminish the potential power of their analyses by treating experience as separate, fragmented, and atomistic.

Constructivist grounded theorists take a reflexive stance toward the research process and products and consider *how* their theories evolve, which involves reflecting on my earlier point that both researchers and research participants interpret meanings and actions. Constructivist grounded theorists assume that both data and analyses are social constructions that reflect what their production entailed (see also Bryant, 2002, 2003; Charmaz, 2000; Hall & Callery, 2001; Thorne, Jensen, Kearney, Noblit & Sandelowski, 2004). In this view, any analysis is contextually situated in time, place, culture, and situation. Because constructivists see facts and values as linked, they acknowledge that what they see—and don't see—rests on values. Thus, constructivists attempt to become aware of their presuppositions and to grapple with how they affect the research. They realize that grounded theorists can ironically import preconceived ideas into their work when they remain unaware of their starting assumptions. Thus, constructivism fosters researchers' reflexivity about their *own* interpretations as well as those of their research participants.

Objectivist Grounded Theory

An objectivist approach to grounded theory contrasts with the constructivist approach. Objectivist grounded theory resides in the positivist tradition and thus attends to data as real in and of themselves and does not attend to the processes of their production.

This stance erases the social context from which data emerge, the influence of the researcher, and often the interactions between grounded theorists and their research participants. Note that most interview excerpts in published reports, including mine, do not give you a sense of how interviewers and their research participants produced the data. An objectivist grounded theorist assumes that data represent objective facts about a knowable world. The data already exist in the world; the researcher finds them and 'discovers' theory from them.

Objectivist grounded theory resides in the positivist tradition and thus attends to data as real in and of themselves and does not attend to the processes of their production.

In this approach, the conceptual sense the grounded theorist makes of data derives from them; meaning inheres in the data and the grounded theorist discovers it (see, for example Corbin & Strauss, 1990; Glaser, 1978; Glaser & Strauss, 1967). This view assumes an external reality awaiting discovery and an unbiased observer who records facts about it. Objectivist grounded theorists believe that careful application of their methods produces theoretical understanding. Hence

their role becomes more of a conduit for the research process rather than a creator of it. Given these assumptions, objectivist proponents would argue for a stricter adherence to grounded theory steps than would constructivists.²

Objectivist grounded theorists remain separate and distant from research participants and their realities, although they may adopt observational methods. Claims of value-free neutrality assume, paradoxically, a value position. Consistent with their assumption of neutrality, these grounded theorists treat how they portray research participants in their written reports as unproblematic. They assume the role of authoritative experts who bring an objective view to the research.

Glaser (see, for example, 1978, 1992, 1998, 2001, 2003) articulates crucial aspects of an objectivist position, despite his disdain of quests for accurate data and insistence that grounded theory is not a verification method.³ I agree with Glaser on the issue of verification. Checking hunches and confirming emergent ideas, in my view, does not equal verification, particularly if one defines verification as entailing systematic quantitative procedures that presuppose establishing firm definitions of the phenomena before studying them. Rather than contributing verified knowledge, I see grounded theorists as offering plausible accounts.

Glaser (2002) treats data as something separate from the researcher and implies that data are untouched by the competent researcher's interpretations. If, perchance, researchers somehow interpret their data, Glaser argues that then these data are 'rendered objective' by looking at many cases. This point contradicts Glaser's vigorous defence of small samples in discussion of saturation. Granted, the number of 'cases' may not always equal sample size but in many grounded theory studies they come close and are minuscule.

Studying many cases is crucial, in part because researchers may become aware of their preconceptions about their topics. Yet such study may not challenge their fundamental assumptions about the world, ways of knowing it, or actions in it. Here, researchers' entrenched assumptions grind the lens for viewing the world and filter their resulting images of it. *What* we define as data and *how* we look at them matters because these acts shape what we *can* see and learn. Without engaging in reflexivity, researchers may elevate their own tacit assumptions and interpretations to 'objective' status. Our assumptions, interactions—and interpretations—affect the social processes constituting *each* stage of inquiry.

Glaser is correct about the value of looking at many cases. Many theorists, including those whose unexamined assumptions predetermine what they see, benefit from looking at many cases because they can strengthen their grasp of their empirical worlds and discern variation in their categories. Surely we learn as we proceed, particularly when we strive to find out what our research participants say and do and what their worlds are like.

A constructivist approach does not adhere to positivist notions of variable analysis or of finding a single basic process or core category in the studied phenomenon. The constructivist view assumes an obdurate, yet ever-changing world but recognizes diverse local worlds and multiple realities, and addresses how people's actions affect their local and larger worlds. Thus, those who take a constructivist approach aim to show the complexities of particular worlds, views, and actions.

Theorizing in Grounded Theory

Critique and Renewal

Where's the theory in grounded theory? Although more researchers claim to have used grounded theory methods than profess to have constructed substantive or formal theories, most hold some sort of conception of theory. If you peruse articles whose authors claim allegiance to grounded theory to see how they construe a finished grounded theory, you might find such varied views as: 1) an empirical generalization, 2) a category, 3) a predisposition, 4) an explication of a process, 5) a relationship between variables, 6) an explanation, 7) an abstract understanding, and 8) a description. Recently, Glaser (2001) described grounded theory as a 'theory of resolving a main concern' that can be theoretically coded in many ways.⁴ Assertions abound about what stands as theory in grounded theory, and that, of course, complicates assessing the extent to which grounded theorists have produced theories. Some observers look at what researchers have done in the name of grounded theory (see, for example, Becker, 1998; Charmaz, 1995b; Silverman, 2001) and note that most studies are descriptive rather than theoretical. Granted, description entails conceptualization but theoretical treatment is also analytic and abstract.

Other observers address the logic of grounded theory. Certainly numerous critics (see, for example, Atkinson, Coffey, & Delamont, 2003; Bulmer, 1979; Dey, 1999, 2004; Emerson, 1983, 2004; Layder, 1998) have challenged presuppositions and prescriptions that they find in grounded theory concerning preconception, pure induction, and procedures. Of course, grounded theorists from different variants have critiqued each other's approaches, as is evident throughout this book (see, for example, Bryant, 2002, 2003; Charmaz, 2000, 2001c, 2005; Clarke, 2005; Corbin, 1998; Glaser, 1992, 2002, 2003; Melia, 1996; Robrecht, 1995; Stern, 1994a; Wilson & Hutchinson, 1996).

Several more criticisms merit discussion. Burawoy (1991) says that grounded theory produces empirical generalizations that lead to generic explanations abstracted from time and place.⁵ Three points are relevant here. First, in contrast to Burawoy, a major strength of grounded theory resides in its applicability across substantive areas. Still, we should reconsider *how* and *when* we move our analysis and ask whether we have gained intimate familiarity with the phenomenon before transporting an analysis.⁶ Second, Burawoy argues that unlike grounded theory, his extended case method (1991) uncovers the particulars of situations, explains how macro foundations shape them, and grounds the reproduction and maintenance of globalization (Burawoy, 2000). He sees grounded theory as leading to astructural analyses and implies that inductive methods and decontextualized generalizations contribute to that result.

What Burawoy suggests that grounded theory cannot do, I argue, is exactly what grounded theory gives us the methods to do (Charmaz, 2005). A contextualized grounded theory can start with sensitizing concepts that address such concepts as power, global reach, and difference and end with inductive analyses that theorize connections between local worlds and larger social structures.

The issue of decontextualized analyses raises further concerns that Burawoy does not mention. Grounded theorists may produce decontextualized analyses

when they disattend to context or are unaware of or unclear about it. Such analyses mask the significance of constructivist elements in grounded theory. Objectivist grounded theorists strive to attain generality and decontextualization typically results. While constructing decontextualized analyses by moving across fields, these grounded theorists may ironically force their data into their earlier generalizations because they lack sufficient contexts with which to ground their new data. Similarly, seeking decontextualized generalities also can reduce opportunities to create theoretical complexity because decontextualizing fosters (over)simplification. Third, Burawoy is right that some empirical generalizations from specific studies do become taken as *generic* statements about larger realities. We might consider at what point these generalizations are granted theoretical status. Who grants them theoretical status—or doesn't? For what purposes? The stress on theorizing leads to consideration of who does the theorizing and with what sort of claims of authority or of conferred authorization.

Burawoy asserts that grounded theory does not consider power in micro contexts and that 'it represses the broader macro forces that both limit change and create domination in the micro sphere' (1991: 282). Burawoy is correct that the originators of grounded theory did not address power. Yet it is quite another issue to attribute the lack of attention to power as a weakness residing within the method itself. The *method*? The method does not preclude attending to power. Layder (1998: 10) raises a similar questionable criticism when he states that grounded theory 'is committed epistemologically (the validity of knowledge) and ontologically (its view of social reality) to denying the existence of phenomena that are not only or simply behavioural (like markets, bureaucracies, and forms of domination).' Not necessarily. Merely because earlier authors did not address power or macro forces does not mean that grounded theory methods cannot. It might mean pursuing mixed methods forms of data collection that include use of documents. Chang's (2000) study of the social transformation of class in China offers valuable clues as to how grounded theorists might study power and macro processes. Adopting grounded theory methods in these areas could wring a new twist to old theoretical clothes.

Burawoy's focus on the objectivist elements in grounded theory leaves out its constructivist potentials. In contrast to Burawoy and Layder's claims, I contend that we should use grounded theory methods in precisely these areas to gain fresh insights in social justice inquiry (Charmaz, 2005b). Clarke's (2005) extensions of grounded theory also encourage pursuing such directions.

Critics from within grounded theory debate what should stand as grounded theory and which directions it should take. Critics from without sometimes reify statements in the early works and turn them into static pronouncements, rather than treating them as starting points or as now historical statements of an evolving method. Most critics have not engaged the full range of sources about grounded theory and a few read no further or deeper than the rhetoric they find in the *Discovery* book (Glaser & Strauss, 1967). Others interpret the method narrowly. These critics commonly miss four crucial points: 1) theorizing is an activity; 2) grounded theory methods provide constructive ways to proceed with this activity; 3) the research problem and the researcher's unfolding interests can

shape the *content* of this activity, not the method; and 4) the products of theorizing reflect how researchers acted on these points.

Critics' reifications about the nature of grounded theory spawn further reifications about its presumed limits. Critics often reify early grounded theory statements. Subsequently, *their* pronouncements are sometimes reified as inherent truths about what grounded theory is and what we can do with it. These reifications influence other interpreters, practitioners, and students of the method. Untested notions about what grounded theory can address spawn reifications about boundaries circumscribing the content of grounded theory studies, such as the belief that grounded theorists cannot use their methods to theorize power. Limited ideas about the form of inquiry grounded theory takes also produce other kinds of reifications. Treating grounded theory as only a variable analysis, for example, can lead to reductionist frames and encourage favoring those 'variables' within ready grasp. Hence, a superficial study can result that may skirt the border of a category without explicating it.

Theory generation continues to be the unfilled promise and potential of grounded theory. As Dan E. Miller (2000: 400) states, 'Although grounded theory (Glaser & Strauss, 1967) is often invoked as a methodological strategy, ironically too little grounded theory is actually done.'

Developing Theoretical Sensitivity through Theorizing

Like other recent texts (see Glaser, 1998; Goulding, 2002; Locke, 2001; Strauss & Corbin, 1998), this volume clarifies the logic and sequence of grounded theory methods. Early grounded theorists predicated constructing theory on developing 'theoretical sensitivity' (Glaser, 1978), but how might grounded theorists acquire it? Which clues can we discover through studying grounded theorists' actions? What do acts of theorizing entail?

Theorizing means stopping, pondering, and rethinking anew. We stop the flow of studied experience and take it apart. To gain theoretical sensitivity, we look at studied life from multiple vantage points, make comparisons, follow leads, and build on ideas. Because you chart your direction through acts of theorizing, you may not be able to foresee endpoints or stops along the way.

The acts involved in theorizing foster *seeing* possibilities, *establishing* connections, and *asking* questions. Grounded theory methods give you theoretical openings that avoid importing and imposing packaged images and automatic answers. How you practice theorizing and how you construct the content of theorizing vary depending on what you find in the field. When you theorize, you reach down to fundamentals, up to abstractions, and probe into experience. The content of theorizing cuts to the core of studied life and poses new questions about it.

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Although tools may help, constructing theory is not a mechanical process. Theoretical playfulness enters in. Whimsy and wonder can lead you to see the

novel in the mundane. Openness to the unexpected expands your view of studied life and subsequently of theoretical possibilities. Your hard work reins in those ideas that best fit the data and brings them to fruition.

Consistent with Glaser's (1978) guidelines, I have stressed using gerunds in coding and memo-writing. Adopting gerunds fosters theoretical sensitivity because these words nudge us out of static topics and into enacted processes.⁷ Gerunds prompt thinking about actions—large and small. If you can focus your coding on *actions*, you have ready grist for seeing sequences and making connections. If your gerunds quickly give way to coding for topics, you may synthesize and summarize data but the connections between them will remain more implicit. Thus, I suggest renewed emphasis on actions and processes, not on individuals, as a strategy in constructing theory and moving beyond categorizing types of individuals.⁸ In my analysis of identity levels in an identity hierarchy, the categories result from people's objectives and actions rather than being pinned to certain individuals. Individuals can and do move up and down the hierarchy and certain social conditions foster such movement while other conditions hinder it.

Taking a closer look at processual analyses may aid your efforts to construct theory.⁹ Studying a process fosters your efforts to construct theory because you define and conceptualize relationships between experiences and events. Then you can define the major phases and concentrate on the relationships between them. Major events and often the pacing may be clear when you study an identifiable process, such as becoming a member of a profession.¹⁰ Graduate degree programs in social work, for example, have definite beginnings and endings and you can discern the pacing and sequencing that lie between. From early on, you know the path and can watch for markers and transitions in the passage. Other processes, such as being selected for lay-off from work or dying of cancer may not be so clear—at least to those who experience these processes and researchers who study them. If so, you may have to do considerable observational and analytic work to define phases that make empirical and theoretical sense.

In their substantive grounded theory of bereavement, Hogan, Morse, and Tasón (1996) outline processes of surviving a death of a close family member. They present their theory as somewhat sequential major processes that may overlap or reemerge:

1. Getting the news
2. Finding out
3. Facing realities
4. Becoming engulfed with suffering
5. Emerging from the suffering
6. Getting on with life
7. Experiencing personal growth

These authors qualify the process according to whether the deceased person had experienced an illness or sudden death. Survivors of a person who suffered a sudden death entered bereavement at the second major phase, finding out, while those whose loved one died of an illness experienced the shock of the terminal diagnosis and a caregiving process. Hogan et al. connect descriptions of grief to specific

phases in the process, and to sub-processes that constitute a particular phase. Thus they treat 'enduring hopelessness,' 'existing in the present,' and 'reliving the past' as part of the 'missing, longing, and yearning' that characterizes how bereaved people experience being engulfed in suffering. Note the strong parallels between these processes and my 1991 analysis of experiencing a serious chronic illness. Both studies tap fundamental phases in suffering and properties of meanings of loss.

If grounded theorists have the methods to construct theory, why do many studies remain descriptive? Coding for themes rather than actions contributes to remaining at a descriptive level. In contrast, grounded theorists have the tools for explicating actions that constitute a process, as Clarke demonstrates in *Disciplining Reproduction* (1998). She persists in analyzing these actions in her treatment of each phase of the two-edged process of scientists establishing their field as a legitimate discipline and exerting controls over women's bodies. Such works keep the *analytic momentum*, and thus extend their theoretical reach further than those that identify a process, outline its phases, and then describe them. One hazard of grounded theory approaches is constructing a list of connected but under-analyzed processes.

Star (1989) keeps the analytic momentum in her analysis of establishing scientific certainty among early brain researchers who believed that mental functions were localized to specific areas of the brain. In her discussion of their tactics for dismissing opponents who argued mental functions were diffuse, she simultaneously shows us localizationists' strategies and theorizes how their actions establish scientific dominance. See how Star maintains her analytic momentum as she discusses the following process:

Manipulating Hierarchies of Credibility

A hierarchy of credibility refers to the differential weight given to the word of people or organizations with different status. That is, a person or institution at the top of a hierarchy is intrinsically more 'believable' than someone at the bottom (Becker, 1967). All else being equal, the word of a Nobel Prize winner is likely to be taken as more plausible than that of a vagrant, even if the content of the statements is the same.

Scientific arguments that manipulate hierarchies of credibility are not sanctioned by scientific method. Yet they are common. The localization debate was not won because localizationists were more sarcastic or *ad hominem* than diffusionists. Instead, localizationists could more effectively manipulate hierarchies of credibility as they gained professional power in medicine and physiology.

'More Scientific than Thou'

Among the types of claims that manipulate hierarchies of credibility are claims on the part of one side or another to [greater] scientificity. These are claims that one procedure or approach is more scientifically viable, or technically astute, than another. Such claims are often opposed to designations like 'metaphysical,' 'poetic,' 'impressionistic,' or 'soft science ...' (1989: 140)

Star starts with a clear definition of her category of 'manipulating hierarchies of credibility,' and then builds its structure by showing how localizationists built the architecture of their argument. Hence, she reaches down into the data and shows how localizationists established that they were 'more scientific than thou,' as one tactic supporting the more general category of 'manipulating hierarchies of credibility.' Subsequently, she fits together being more scientific than thou with other tactics that support and specify the larger category, including 'arguments from authority' and 'ignoring, censorship, and sarcasm.' In each case, she shows how localizationists used these tactics and gave reasons why they invoked them. Because Star gives her categories and subcategories imagery and substance, she constructs a dense theoretical statement that readers remember. This excerpt shows how writing style and theoretical significance merge in the narrative. Star's engaging style persuades readers and involves them in her theoretical arguments.

To maintain analytic momentum, try to remain open to theoretical possibilities. Recall that Glaser (1978, 1998) advises you to begin the analytic process by asking, 'What is this data a study of?' (1978: 57). If we ask the question at *each* stage of the analytic process and seek the most fundamental answer that fits, we might discover that particular meanings and actions in our studied world suggest theoretical links to compelling ideas that had not occurred to us. As we pursue theoretical possibilities, we may make connections between our theoretical categories and ideas concerning the core of human experience. If so, our study may be about fundamental views and values such as those concerning human nature, selfhood, autonomy and attachment, moral life and responsibility, legitimacy and control, and certainty and truth. For example, my study of struggling for self in the identity hierarchy linked selfhood, autonomy, legitimacy, and control.

Any field contains fundamental concerns and contested ideas, whether or not they have yet been theorized. As we code data and write memos, we can think about which ones, if any, our materials suggest and how our completed theories address them. In my field of sociology, such concerns include:

- Embodiment and consciousness
- Individual and collective action
- Cooperation and conflict
- Choice and constraint
- Meanings and actions
- Standpoints and differences
- Ritual and ceremony
- Positions and networks
- Power and prestige
- Structure and process
- Opportunities and inequalities
- Rights and resources
- Moral life, moral action, and moral responsibility

Discerning connections to such concerns opens possibilities for theorizing. What deflects them? Analytic starting points matter. The early grounded

theory texts prescribed discovering a single basic process. If numerous 'basic' social processes occur in a setting, determining 'the' most fundamental process can be daunting, even for an objectivist grounded theorist. While I had no difficulty defining loss of self (Charmaz, 1983b) as more basic than 'managing illness' or 'disclosing illness' in my study of experiencing chronic illness, I could not define a single basic process that unified everything I was learning. For several years I wrestled with trying to identify one basic social process that captured everything I learned about experiencing illness.¹¹ I tried to find a more specific process than 'experiencing illness'; however, people experienced many processes ranging from learning to live with chronic illness to experiencing time in new ways to recreating or reestablishing a self they could accept.

Once the analytic work begins, all the potential problems mentioned above may arise. Thus, some grounded theories suffer from what John Lofland (1970) calls 'analytic interruptus' in qualitative research. The analytic work begins but comes to an abrupt ending. A disjuncture arises between the analytic level in these grounded theory studies and the goal of theorizing. Cathy Urquhart (2003) attributes this disjuncture in her field of information systems to subjective elements in coding. She states:

Experience with using GTM [Grounded Theory Methods] shows that it is essentially a 'bottom up' coding method. Therefore, it is not unusual for researchers to find that GTM gives them a low level theory which they find difficult to 'scale up' appropriately.

One issue then, in our use of GTM in IS [Information Systems] is to clearly identify what we are using it for: a) a coding method or b) a method of theory generation. There is ample evidence in IS literature for the first use, much less for the second. One useful side effect of using GTM in IS could be a much more detailed consideration of the role of theory – and generation of our own theories specific to IS. (2003: 47)

Urquhart's astute assessment applies to many grounded theory researchers throughout the disciplines who stop their analytic work after coding and constructing elementary categories. In contrast to Urquhart, however, I argue that the bottom-up approach gives grounded theory its strength. The subjectivity of the observer provides a *way* of viewing. Instead of arresting analysis at the coding stage, researchers can raise their main categories to concepts.

Categories are major and minor. Which categories does a researcher raise to theoretical concepts? Consistent with grounded theory logic, you raise the categories that render the data most effectively. Clarke views these categories as having 'carrying capacity' because they carry substantial analytic weight.¹² These categories contain crucial properties that make data meaningful and carry the analysis forward. We choose to raise certain categories to concepts because of their theoretical reach, incisiveness, generic power, and relation to other categories. Raising categories to concepts includes subjecting them to further analytic refinement and involves showing their relationships to other concepts. For objectivists, these concepts serve as core variables and hold explanatory and predictive power. For constructivists, theoretical concepts serve as

interpretive frames and offer an abstract understanding of relationships. Theoretical concepts subsume lesser categories and by comparison hold more significance, account for more data and often are more evident. We make a series of decisions about these categories after having compared them with other categories and the data. Our actions shape the analytic process. Rather than discovering order *within* the data, we create an explication, organization, and presentation of the data (Charmaz, 1990).

Inspecting Grounded Theories

While keeping meanings of theory and theorizing practices in mind, we can take a fresh look at theory construction in several grounded theories I introduced earlier. Each theory bears the imprint of its author's interests and ideas and reflects its historical context as well as the historical development of ideas—and of grounded theory—in its parent discipline. Each of the theories published in the 1980s mirrors the form and style of the era. Before Clifford and Marcus's (1986) postmodern challenge in *Writing Culture*, most qualitative researchers strove to be objective and positivist. As Van Maanen (1988) suggests, Glaser and Strauss (1967) created methods that emulated the natural sciences and provided researchers with a defense against accusations of subjectivity.¹³

Jane Hood's Substantive Theory

Jane Hood's (1983) book stands out because she outlines specific theoretical conditions that explain substantive problems and processes. Compared to today, more working- and middle-class women with children married their male partners at the time Hood collected her data and fewer married women felt forced to reenter the workforce after having children. Many women—married or not—must work now and earlier cultural values have changed that both dissuaded mothers from working and fostered fathers' lack of involvement in family work.

As I pointed out in the previous chapter, Hood found that husbands' awareness and acknowledged value of their wives' significant contributions to family finances became underlying conditions for sharing family work. Those husbands who valued their wives' financial contribution participated in housework and childcare. Those husbands who did not see their wives as coproviders did not view housework and childcare as a joint effort.

Thus the husband's definition of the situation and in particular of the wife's financial contribution became variables on which outcomes rested. Note that Hood specifies what happens when the husband acknowledges and values his wife's financial contribution *and* what happens when he does not.

Hood was influenced by Glaser and, not surprisingly, her mode of analysis reflects that influence. Like other grounded theories of the early 1980s, Hood's analysis has an objectivist cast. She seeks explanations and offers predictions. Although she engages her participants in lively discussions and raises occasional pointed questions, she offers crisp, straightforward assessments of her data from an expert's vantage point. Hood identifies variables, specifies conditions under which

events and actions occur, and examines consequences. Her statements are parsimonious and integrated and she deduces testable hypotheses from them. Hood shows what people do and identifies the source of further action. She maintains analytic momentum throughout her research. As she studied her data and engaged in theoretical sampling, Hood made her theory more dense by addressing whether work-oriented spouses were more or less likely to stay together; which kinds of wives remained in the workforce, how their relative commitments to work and their wage ratios affected their bargaining power; and what categories of husbands correspondingly increased their household responsibilities. Consider this set of hypotheses that Hood deduced after she had articulated her theory:

1. Wives working for 'self' as opposed to 'family' reasons will be more likely to remain in the labor force after the need for their incomes has diminished.
2. Couples with competing goals will experience more strain than those with complementary goals.
3. Increased work commitment on the part of a wife (accompanied by a decrease in the amount of companionship she is able to offer her husband) will cause most problems in husband- and couple-centered marriages and least in child-centered marriages.
4. Wives working for self reasons married to job-oriented men are most likely to move toward recognition as coproviders (and increase their wage ratio).
5. Couples who are most ambivalent about their definition of the wife's responsibility to provide will be likely to resolve this inconsistency either by having the wife quit work or by accepting her as a coprovider.
6. Job-oriented husbands will have an easier time accepting their wives' increased work commitment than will career-oriented husbands.
7. Job-oriented husbands and families with younger children will be most likely to increase their share of household responsibility, where career-oriented husbands and fathers of older children will be less likely to.
8. Regardless of her share of the family income, a wife's bargaining power will be improved by gains in self-esteem and increased social support outside the marriage. (1983: 138)

These hypotheses follow Hood's theory of the role bargaining process based on her analysis of outcomes concerning specific research participants. If we conducted a similar study today we might cast a wider initial net to discover if, how, when, and to what extent other factors such as race or ethnic identification, religious beliefs, and geographical location might affect what happens during the bargaining process and, should patterns emerge, subsequently earn their way into the analysis. For that matter, we would want to see what contemporary couples bargain about and learn whether and to what extent they have reframed the issues since Hood's original study. A contemporary researcher likely would attend to the range of variation in the bargaining process and to situating the subsequent analysis.

A further examination of Hood's type of analysis shows its usefulness in defining *what* happened and in theorizing its implications. She reveals how

implicit rules and tacit agreements about rights and obligations shape bargaining. She points out that her research participants share a tacit agreement that a wife cannot expect help with housework unless she has to work for family survival. Children, in contrast, result in joint responsibilities that spouses must cover if one partner cannot fulfill his or her tasks. Hood's couples assumed that children must receive a certain amount of parental attention and thus a spouse felt compelled to maintain that level commensurate to his or her partner's reduced involvement with the children.

Interview data may provide accounts indicating *how* couples negotiate family work from the perspectives of the men and women involved but interviews are just that—retrospective accounts subject to reconstruction in view of present exigencies and purposes. Nevertheless, Hood's multiple methods of data collection do much to counteract the limitations of interviews. Her interview accounts indicate hypothetical conditions concerning *when* negotiation is possible. We learn *why* wives may be effective or ineffective in obtaining their husbands' participation in family work. We certainly gain a sense of *whose* perspectives and prerogatives prevail first, but we don't know how strongly women whose husbands did not participate in family work felt that they should. Nor do we know how these women may have tried to impose their definitions. Interestingly, Hood did discover that men's participation in family work had the consequence of couples becoming closer. Her data may not open up the process of becoming closer but certainly points the way for further research to examine how this process may unfold.

Hood's analysis shows the social conditions at play with remarkable clarity. Not only does Hood maintain analytic momentum but also she is unwavering in her focus. Once she discovers her core variables, she proceeds to trace out their permutations and implications and integrate them in a logically precise framework. Her hypothetical statements supply tools for making predictions and for transporting the analysis to study other types of situations. For example, we could observe whether and to what extent the analysis holds for two-career couples without children.

By developing integrated conditional statements, Hood moves her analysis from empirical generalizations about a small sample to a substantive theory of an empirical problem. The conceptual level of this theory is specific and immediate. Hood shows how we can theorize concrete relationships in ways that provide a useful handle to evaluate actual situations.

Hood built early comparisons into her research that gave her the foundation to make distinctions and to pursue differences about her major concerns of role overload and marital equity. Consistent with Glaser's current emphasis on studying how people resolve a pressing problem in their lives, she stuck with analyzing if and how working women could negotiate the constant problem of family work. Take note that Hood completed her study long before Glaser's (1998) definitive statements appeared about studying how people resolve a problem.

Because of her systematic approach to data-gathering, making comparisons, and theoretical sampling, Hood could generate conditions that characterized her emerging substantive theory and contributed to its coalescence. Her theory readily permits researchers and readers alike to check empirical instances.

Hood conducted her study as an independent research project although we can easily envision transporting her approach to a large multi-method project that combines qualitative research with comprehensive national quantitative surveys. This study suggests how well certain qualitative grounded approaches could work with multi-method and multi-disciplinary research teams that address specific research problems.

Patrick Biernacki's Theory of a Basic Social Process

Patrick Biernacki's *Pathways from Heroin Addiction* (1986) offers a theoretical explication of a basic social process, as consistent with early grounded theory texts (Glaser, 1978; Glaser & Strauss, 1967). His theory accounts for the identity transformation from 'addict' to 'ex-addict' among individuals who did not seek treatment. Biernacki demonstrates the phases in the process and treats them as conceptual categories. He arrives at these categories by pulling together processes defined in his codes. I present a diagram (Figure 6.1) to show the logic of Biernacki's processual theory but only detail the last crucial phase of the process, which I discuss below.

Biernacki's theory has a strong objectivist foundation with some interpretivist elements. He traces the sequence of events and shows how sub-processes build on each other. After ex-addicts quelled their drug cravings and stayed abstinent, Biernacki argues that they underwent subtle social psychological processes involving symbolic and social reconstructions of their lives and worlds. These reconstructions required making a place in the conventional world. Such symbolic and social reconstructions usually presented addicts with harrowing problems and continued troubles—but overcoming them remained a prerequisite for completing their identity transformation. Thus, the category of 'becoming and being "ordinary"' (p. 141) became an integral concept in Biernacki's theory. He shows how his research participants experienced this phase of the transformation process. Recovering addicts had to adopt and maintain conventional lives. Yet they felt reluctant to interact with conventional people and simultaneously faced stereotyped views of addicts as untrustworthy, loathsome individuals.

To make his theory coalesce, Biernacki needed to explain the pivotal role that 'becoming and being "ordinary"' played in the recovery process to *theorize* how addicts' identity transformation became real. What happened to make this transformation possible? How did social circumstances and personal choices congeal to lead to a complete identity transformation? Biernacki's categories below refer to three different identity paths that addicts traversed to become ordinary:

- Emergent identities (pp. 144–148)
- Reverting to unspoiled identities (pp. 149–155)
- Extending identities (pp. 155–160).

Thus in the first case, recovering addicts' new identities emerged as they adopted new pursuits that absorbed their attention and spawned identity change. In the second case, constructing a former conventional identity eventually

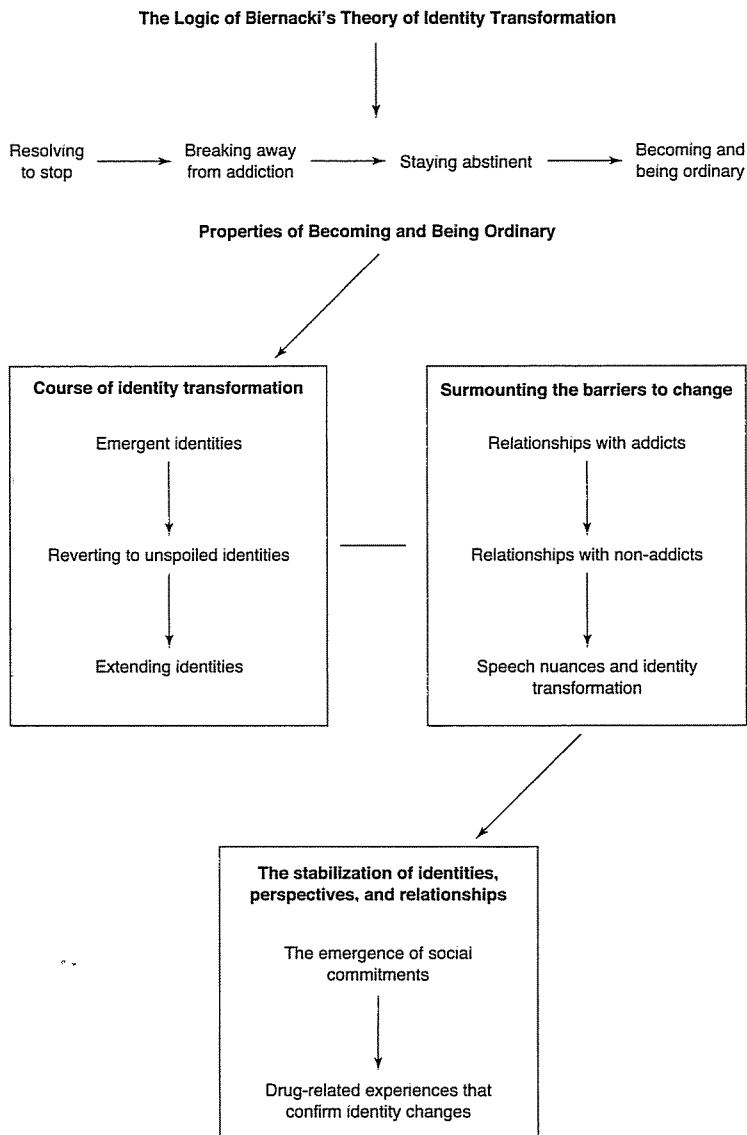


FIGURE 6.1 Patrick Biernacki's theory of identity transformation in recovery from addiction without treatment

allowed leaving the addict identity behind, and in the third, expanding an unspoiled identity that had remained intact during addiction created possibilities for identity change. Emergent identities developed through circumstance and action, often without forethought. Reverting to an unspoiled identity and

extending a present one were more apt to result from conscious choices. Each category maps an identity path to becoming and being ordinary.

Biernacki's identity categories exhaust the range of empirical instances that he discovered in the field. Thus, his concept 'being and becoming "ordinary"' derives from empirical indicators and accounts for them. Biernacki had to address simultaneous processes to have his theory coalesce. While engaged in these kinds of identity-work, addicts involved themselves in 'surmounting the barriers to change,' the next major problem that Biernacki defines in their transformation. Last, ex-addicts had to stabilize their new or revised identities, perspectives, and relationships (pp. 161–180). If we take a closer look at Biernacki's category 'surmounting the barriers to change,' and examine how he treats it, we can see how he wove his data, codes, and categories into a theoretical explanation that builds directly from the data. Recovering addicts had to reject enticements offered by their addicted peers and, moreover, resist the power and pervasiveness of the drug world and its discourse. Meanwhile, addicts had to surmount the stigma of addiction in conventional worlds and prove that they had changed. Biernacki has already defined *when* surmounting these barriers becomes crucial. Next he looks at *how* ex-addicts established proof of their changed identities.

How can this be done? Well, proof might be found in the ex-addicts' maintaining some of the involvements thought of as typical of a conventional, 'ordinary' life over an extended period of time. For example, ex-addicts are expected to be steadily employed, to maintain their own places of residence, and to keep reasonably 'normal' hours. They should also possess the material things that are common in the nonaddictive world—say, a television set and a stereo. Ex-addicts must avoid, or at least not be seen in, 'deviant' places, especially those areas known to be frequented by drug addicts. They should frequent 'normal' places—the cinema, restaurants, or sports events—and when they do, they should pay their own way.

These may seem like small concerns, but they are important because they go against the stereotypic images that non-addicted people have of addicts ... By the addicts' actions and even their possessions, others assess whether their claims that they are no longer using drugs and have changed their lives are true. (Biernacki, 1986: 166–167)

Biernacki provides an integrated substantive theory of identity change among addicts who do not receive treatment. His theory is sufficiently abstract to cover the range of empirical situations. Biernacki tackles the theoretical concept of identity by systematically constructing categories that synthesize and explain his research participants' accounts of their experiences. As he defined and conceptualized patterns in the data, he sought further data to specify conditions that affected the recovery. Not surprisingly, Biernacki discovered that a major factor was the extent to which a person's participation in the world of addiction excluded conventional pursuits. But Biernacki did not stop there. Rather, he also juxtaposed immersion in the drug world again against access and costs, and discovered how they varied. Biernacki found that addicts' immersion in the drug world seemed to be most complete when their drug costs were high and

access was difficult. Subsequently, he began theoretical sampling among doctors and nurses. These professionals not only had low drug costs and relatively easy access but possessed valued identities with demanding involvements. By pursuing patterns in his data, Biernacki explains *why* certain addicts recover without treatment.

The theoretical reach of Biernacki's analysis extends beyond drug addiction. He addresses a generic process of identity transformation in a particular category of people that we could transport across fields to develop the concepts further. Other forms of deviant behavior, such as delinquency and prostitution, offer possibilities for advancing or modifying Biernacki's theory.

Kathy Charmaz's Constructivist Theory

The discussion below clarifies how a constructivist approach encourages you to theorize in the interpretive tradition. Interpretive theorizing may cover overt processes but also delves into implicit meanings and processes and is most evident then. To follow my reasoning, take another look at the category 'living one day at a time'. The idea of living one day at a time appeared in my data as part of the taken-for-granted discourse among chronically ill people. People stated the need to live one day at a time as an obvious fact but did not elaborate on it. A constructivist approach leads you to explore and interpret such implicit statements or actions.

Living One Day at a Time

Living one day at a time means dealing with illness—each day—but only one at a time. When people do so, they hold future plans and even ordinary pursuits in abeyance. For most people, living one day at a time tacitly acknowledges their fragility.

Living one day at a time also allows people to focus on illness, treatment, and regimen without being overcome by dashed hopes and unmet expectations. Taking this stance provides guidelines for functioning each day and confers some sense of control. By concentrating on the present, the person can avoid or minimize thinking about further disability and death.

The felt need to live one day at a time can drastically alter one's time perspective. Living one day at a time pulls the person's attention into the present and pushes once projected futures further away. Earlier visions of the future recede without disruption and slip away, perhaps almost unnoted. The present is compelling and, eventually, may seem rewarding. If so, the content of time changes; moments become longer and fuller.

Living one day at a time is a strategy for managing chronic illness and structuring time. Moreover, it also provides a way of managing self while facing uncertainty. It gives a sense of control over one's actions and, by extension, a sense of control over self and situation. Embracing this strategy also alters time perspective. ...

Living one day at a time reveals emotions embedded in the experience of illness. Many ill people, especially older people, express greater fear of dependence, debility, and abandonment than of death. Living one day at a

time helps to reduce their fear that the future will be worse than the present. During a series of setbacks, Mark Reinertsen murmured, 'I try to live one day at a time because it is just less frightening.' Later he observed, 'I could just get really tied up in what might happen [death or further deterioration] since so much has happened in the last six months [multiple complications and iatrogenic diseases]. But what good does it do? I can only handle today?' (1991a, pp. 178, 180-181)

This excerpt represents an instance of constructivist analysis because it pieces together and interprets implicit meanings that constitute the category, thereby showing how a mundane statement alludes to an array of meanings and experiences. I point out actions that people take although the content of the category *relies* on how I assemble these actions and stated feelings and the interpretation I give to participants' statements and actions. When we delve into tacit meanings, not everyone we talk with is equally adept at describing them or of linking their actions to these meanings. Thus, the researcher may develop special methodological as well as analytic strategies to learn about relevant meanings and actions.

The narrative above pulls together disparate experiences in the category and elucidates the range of its tacit meanings. An interpretive analysis invites the reader's imaginative participation in related experiences through the *theoretical rendering* of the category. In this sense, the theoretical understanding of the category creates its significance; without it, research participants' unexplicated statements about living one day at a time would remain unexamined asides that happened to occur during the course of conversation. Pure description, in contrast, invites readers into scenes and invokes interest in and, often, identification with research participants' stories. The significance of the experience is often straightforward, as when Hood and Biernacki offer telling descriptions of their research. Their descriptions underscore the plausibility of their explanations.

Consistent with a constructivist approach, the view I have of the data is part of their rendering. That is also true of Hood and Biernacki's grounded theories, but it is a matter of extent. Hood and Biernacki's theories both cover definitive events with clear markers and tangible experiences. Other trained observers in their respective fields could see and chart similar processes, once they made the respective initial empirical and conceptual leaps that Hood and Biernacki made. (In Hood's case that meant ferreting out the reasons why working women received little household help from husbands and in Biernacki's case, if and how heroin addicts recover from addiction without treatment.)

My analysis above remains more intuitive and impressionistic than Hood's or Biernacki's. Whether or not its interpretive frame strengthens or weakens it redounds back to critics' allegiances to constructivist or objectivist grounded theory. Would other researchers have drawn out the relationship between past and future or treated it as a strategy to maintain emotional control? Conceivably—if they already possessed some theoretical sensitivity toward concepts of self, time, emotions, and life disruptions. If not, it's hard to say because the properties of the category remain implicit until theoretical sampling and interpretive rendering make them explicit. The further we go into implicit experience, the longer it may take to make such empirical and conceptual

leaps. Might other researchers have seen different things in the experience and by extension, the category? Yes, that's possible. Perhaps the kinds of theoretical sensitivities that the researcher brings to studied life assume special significance here. The analysis results from the researcher's involvement at every point in the research process.

Part of the interpretive task is being alert to possibilities for moving the analysis beyond the definitive evidence you currently have. That's why subsequent entering or reentering the experience is crucial. Rather than viewing living one day at a time as a convenient slogan, I sampled further to find out if and how people acted on it. Observers may be able to reenter the scene; interviewers can only seek access to stories that might illuminate the category. In this case, theoretical sampling became a means of gaining access to this specific experience. By going back and exploring further questions, the fragments of experience took form.

What place do categories have in constructivist analyses? Although categories do not serve as core variables, researchers may show relationships among them. In this case, I conveyed how my category 'living one day at a time' connected with three major concepts: 'Time Perspectives,' 'Time Structures,' and 'Situating the Self in Time.' Thus, living one day at a time shapes the time structure of someone's days and weeks. Taking this stance for long periods alters the person's time perspective as the past fades and the future wanes. As a result, the person locates his or her self in the present.

Like Hood and Biernacki, I specify conditions, show conceptual relationships, and forecast consequences. Rather than making explicit theoretical propositions, I weave them into the narrative. Although the theory is more diffuse than either Hood's or Biernacki's, simultaneously, it is more abstract and general. Certainly the content of inquiry influences the theoretical outcomes. The elusive nature of my dual emphases on the self and time contributes to how I developed my theoretical statements. Still, a constructivist grounded theory informed my emerging analysis and inspired making fresh theoretical connections.

Concluding Thoughts

Throughout this chapter, I drew firm lines between positivist and interpretive inquiry, constructivist and objectivist grounded theory, and the subsequent distinctions and directions they suggest. In research practice, however, the lines may not be so clear. Positivist researchers may explore elusive topics with ephemeral meanings. Constructivist grounded theorists may investigate overt processes in painstaking detail. In research practice, theorizing means being eclectic, drawing on what works, defining what fits (see also Wuest, 2000). For that matter, neither positivist nor constructivist may intend that readers view their written grounded theories as *Theory*, shrouded in all its grand mystique, or acts of theorizing. Instead they just are doing grounded theory in whatever way they understand it.

Like Star's early brain researchers, however, grounded theorists sometimes invoke a 'more theoretical than thou' form of invidious comparison. An elegant

parsimonious theory may offer clear propositions but have limited scope. An imaginative diffuse theory may spark bursts of insight but offer interpretive frames with porous borders. Each presupposes different objectives and favors certain ways of knowing and types of knowledge. A theory allows us to cut through ordinary explanations and understandings and to attend to certain realities and not to others. Theories cannot be measured like bank statements although we can establish criteria for different kinds of theorizing. The balance of If-Then theoretical propositions and the number and density of abstractions depends on a grounded theorist's audience and purpose as well as on his or her theoretical proclivities. As my above discussions of theorizing in grounded theory reveal, theories serve different purposes and differ in their inclusiveness, precision, level, scope, generality, and applicability.

The subjectivity and ambiguity I portrayed in constructivist grounded theory permeates objectivist approaches as well. These approaches mask subjectivity and ambiguity through shared assumptions about the world and established formats for conducting research. In the end, inquiry takes us outward yet reflecting about it draws us inward. Subsequently, grounded theory leads us back to the world for a further look and deeper reflection—again and again. Our imaginative renderings of what we see and learn are interpretations, emanating from dialectics of thought and experience. Whether we adhere to positivist or interpretive traditions, we do not gain an autonomous theory, albeit one amenable to modification. Rather we are *part* of our constructed theory and this theory reflects the vantage points inherent in our varied experiences, whether or not we are aware of them.

NOTES

- 1 After completing a chapter-length analysis of this material by 1983, the published version appeared in 1987. I had laid out the central ideas in my dissertation (1973) but in the interim I had collected more data to refine the categories.
- 2 For a more complete statement of contrasts distinguishing constructivist and objectivist grounded theory, see Charmaz, 2000; 2006a.
- 3 I agree with Glaser (1992) on the issue of verification, despite its appearance in the *Discovery* (1967) book. Checking hunches and confirming ideas, in my view, does not equal verification. Rather than contributing verified knowledge, I see grounded theorists as offering plausible accounts.
- 4 Glaser (2001) now argues that researchers identify this main concern, which represents a significant departure from his (1992) assertion that researchers should analyze the main concern in the setting and that participants will tell them what it is.
- 5 Burawoy calls for 'grounded globalizations' (2000: 341) and an agenda for 'grounding globalization' later in *Global Ethnography* (2000: 337–373). Although his concepts allude to grounded theory, he does not engage or cite it.
- 6 My point here complements Silverman's (2004) argument cited above.
- 7 An emphasis on gerunds may seem like a trivial point; instead I see it as a pivotal point but one that grounded theorists do not always adopt. Perhaps the much greater emphasis on structure than process in the English language makes thinking with gerunds unfamiliar; however, researchers often find that gerunds fit much of their data in ways they had not—and could not have—fully anticipated.

- 8 Learning to focus on processes instead of on individuals and topics was one of our first lessons in our grounded theory analysis seminars during my graduate years. We learned to go beyond static typologies labeling individuals into analyzing basic social processes to give the studied phenomenon fuller analytic treatment. Many qualitative studies at the time relied on labeling individuals, so developing explicit analyses of social processes in grounded theory marked a decided advance.
- 9 Numerous grounded theory studies offer insightful observations of subjective experience or organizational processes (see, for example, Hogan, Morse, & Tasón, 1996; Lempert, 1996; Melia, 1987; Thulesius, Håkansson, & Petersson, 2003; Tweed & Salter, 2000) and increasingly more grounded theory studies provide useful treatment of larger social processes (see for example Clarke, 1998; Star, 1989, 1999).
- 10 The level we address figures here. Although many grounded theorists study process as indicated in narratives or natural settings, to my knowledge we have not addressed interactional sequences as closely as conversational analysts (see, for example, Maynard, 2003; Silverman, 1997). Urquhart's (1998) study, which builds on system analysis, takes a step in this direction.
- 11 In my dissertation (1973), which addressed the same substantive area, I made 'remobilizing' the major process. Besides being an ugly word that evokes mechanistic and militaristic images, the term did not account for the range of experience. This decided limitation became increasingly apparent when I gathered additional and more complete data after the dissertation. By then, I had improved my interviewing skills and routinely tape-recorded the interviews.
- 12 Personal communication, February 28, 2005.
- 13 In the 1960s, many scholars dismissed qualitative research as impressionistic, unsystematic, and subjective.